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論 Kuso 影片之意義協商與身分認同的語境化現象
-- 從社會符號學角度進行多模態分析

Kuso videos as a genre for meaning negotiation and identity contextualization: Toward a social-semiotic multimodal analysis

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Kuso Videos as a Genre for Meaning Negotiation and Identity Contextualization: Toward a Social-Semiotic Multimodal Analysis

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摘要

透過網路影片平台 Youtube 的分享，Kuso 影片近來成爲網路上頗爲盛行的新興文類，以 kuso 影片方式對台灣社會的種種議題表達看法已蔚爲風潮。因此，本研究主要探討 kuso 影片製作過程中的意義創造機制。有別於以往相關研究大多關注單一模態的 kuso 呈現方式，如：文字或圖片， 本研究將分析 Youtube 上的多模態與多媒介的 kuso 影片，並著重探討影片的表演性、影響力與潛在意義，藉以探索下列研究問題：

一，從多模態社會符號學的觀點來看，kuso 影片的潛藏意義如何在創造過程中展現出來？

二，在多模態 kuso 影片中，如何定義模態 (mode)？模態的限制條件爲何？是否可將單一模態視爲創造多模態影片潛藏意義的個別單位？

三，從社會符號學的角度來看，掌控或參與 kuso 影片製作的角色爲何？亦即，在創造影片意義的過程中，如何將影片當中的身分認同語境化並與其他參與者(評論 kuso 影片者)進行協商？

四，在 kuso 影片製作與傳播的過程中，去語境化、重構語境與身分認同之語境化三者的相互關聯性爲何？

本研究引用多模態符號模型 (Halliday, 1978; Lim, 2002) 與 Bakhtin (1981;

1986) 所提出的文類理論，作爲分析架構的基礎，並透過「身分認同之投射行爲」(projective act of identity) 理論 (Coupland, 2007)，闡釋 kuso 影片中身份認同語境化的現象。此外，本研究提出「功能性多模態符號學模型」，以實例解說經由去語境化、重構語境與身分認同之語境化的過程中，如何展現不同層次的意義組合，並說明其語言符號功能 (概念、篇章與人際功能)。整體而言，本研究旨在分析並闡明多模態 kuso 複雜的意義創造過程，希望對此研究議題有所貢獻。

關鍵詞：kuso 影片、文類、多模態分析、互文性、混合、身分認同之語境化

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Abstract

Kuso videos as an emergent Internet genre have gained its popularity among a great number of online participants, especially via the most popular video-sharing website, Youtube. The present study explores the meaning-making mechanism that operates in the production of kuso videos, which are worthy of note inasmuch as they have been more and more widely used in response to issues arising in Taiwanese society. Different from previous research on monomodal representation of kuso (e.g. written, graphic kuso), the present research takes the previous studies as a point of departure and will analyze a multimodal and multimedial kuso video uploaded onto Youtube. The analysis will center around its performance, power, and meaning potentials and seek to answer the following research questions.

(1) From a multimodal social-semiotic perspective, how are the meaning potentials of kuso videos being performed in the process of meaning-making?

(2) In multimodal kuso videos, what accounts as a mode and what are the affordances of a specific mode? Or, is it necessary to define mode as a separate unit which creates meaning potentials in the whole multimodal production?

(3) In social-semiotic production of kuso videos, who is in control in the process of meaning-making? In other words, in the meaning-making process, how is the

identity of kuso video being contextualized and being negotiated with other participants?

(4) How are decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization interconnected to each other in the production and the distribution of kuso videos?

To analyze the meaning-making process and meaning potentials of the target kuso video, multisemiotic models (Halliday, 1978; Lim, 2002) as well as Bakhtin's (1981; 1986) genre theory are applied as the basis of the analytical framework while "projective act of identity" (Coupland, 2007) is used to account for the how identity is contextualized in the video. In addition, the present research proposes the Functional Multisemiotic Model to illustrate with examples how layers of remix operate in the processes of decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization and to elucidate what semiotic functions they serve at three levels (i.e. ideational, textual, and interpersonal levels). On the whole, this research may shed light on the intricate meaning-making process in multimodal kuso analysis.

Key words: kuso video, genre, multimodal analysis, intertextuality, remix, identity contextualization

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Kuso videos as a genre for meaning negotiation and identity contextualization: Toward a social-semiotic multimodal analysis

Chapter 1. Introduction

1.1 Background

Due to the popularization of the Internet and the advance of technology, digital folklore has become one of the most important human cultures in this century, representing the emergence of new practices in human communication. The term "digital folklore" is closely related to the popular use of computer-mediated communication via various digital communicative channels, such as e-mail, chat room, Facebook, etc, thus having triggered a great deal of research on "computer-mediated discourse" (e.g. Murray 1989; Jacobson, 1996; Herring, 2001). Originally, emerging in the late eighteen century, the notion of folklore was known as "a unified vision of language, CULTURE, literature, and ideology in the service of romantic nationalism" (Bauman, 1992, p. 29). That is, individuals who shared a form of folklore (e.g. customs, superstitions, and proverbs) were thought to belong to a distinctive people or society. More recently, Ben-Amos (2006) redefined the notion of folklore by emphasizing the need to examine the phenomenon in which folklore exists; moreover, he regarded

folklore as a “communicative process” (p. 9) in which certain meaning potentials are articulated in its cultural contexts instead of an accumulation of different things. In this sense, folklore may reflect the social-cultural changes in relation to communicative purpose in human societies. For example, various subgenres, including e-mail, blog, online video, instant messaging, online forums and Youtube video, have emerged from the Internet and have been used by people around the world.

Particularly, Internet kuso, presented in a combination of different forms (e.g. written forms, images, and videos), may be seen as a pervasive genre for particular meaning-making. Take political debate for example. Traditionally, campaign commercials are produced by political parties to debate over certain issues or to achieve particular political appeals, such as winning elections; however, more and more political videos for debate have been produced by a number of “amateur” individual online participants who are skilled at video editing by appropriating and remixing different modes, materials, and other available resources to create new videos. Namely, these political kuso videos on Youtube are often produced by individuals to make political irony, to attract general public’s attention, or to achieve political appeal.

In fact, with the appearance of the Youtube, multimodal representation of kuso video has gained its popularity in the recent five years. The term “kuso”, originating from a Japanese expression which means “shit”, was often used as a taboo meaning

“damn” and later it referred to how players could have fun from playing dull video games in Japan (Lo, 2006, p. 6). In Taiwan, the term “kuso” initially occurred in the forum of “KUSO GAME” in the Bulletin Board System (BBS) in 2000 and had become a popular genre represented in written or image forms from 2001 to 2005 (p. 10). After 2005, kuso videos have become a very popular tool for entertainment, spoof, parody, irony, or critique (p. 11). In other words, the meaning of kuso transforms from “shit” in Japanese to “spoof” or “parody” referring to the relaxing, funny, or ironic representation of serious topics in Taiwanese society.

The present study explores the meaning-making mechanism that operates in the production of kuso videos. Kuso videos are worthy of note inasmuch as they have been more and more widely used in response to issues arising in Taiwanese society. The present research regards kuso videos as an emergent multimodal genre which represents a kind of “Netspeak” (Crystal, 2001, p. 41) mediated by the online environment and constrained by the affordances of technology. Kuso videos may be seen as a language which has its semiotic features, performance, and communicative functions. In other words, the definition of language is not confined to verbal presentation but may include any forms of representation in which meaning potentials are articulated.

Since kuso videos can be seen as multimodal and multimedial cultural production (Kress & Van Leeuwen, 2001; Kress, 2010), one of the central concepts in multimodal

communication, “multimodal communication as new literacy”, will also be applied to account for the essential factors in comprehending kuso videos as a genre. In multimodal communication, the concept “new literacy” has been widely discussed. According to Coiro, Knobel, Lankshear, and Leu (2008), new literacy is no longer a static concept but a dynamic process involving text composition, comprehension and communication. Namely, the process is the practice of remix in which writers utilize and construct different resources (Lessing, 2005). In addition, based on Lankshear and Knobel (2006), the notion of “remix” also refers to “literacy” because both of them are “socially recognized ways of generating, communicating, and negotiating meaningful content through the medium of encoded texts of participation in Discourses” (p. 108). That is, particular literacies may be seen as cultural products which can only be meaningful in specific socio-cultural contexts.

Therefore, it is of great importance for the present research to analyze how the notion of remix operates in the meaning-making process of kuso videos and what the required multimodal literacies are to comprehend a kuso video.

1.2 Research purpose

Since kuso culture in Taiwan began only a decade ago, not many studies have been conducted; nevertheless, from the perspective of multimodal literacies, some scholars

(e.g. Lankshear & Knobel, 2006; Jenkins, 2006; Tryon, 2008) have investigated the issues of parody and irony, which are similar to one of the functions that kuso can serve. For example, Lankshear and Knobel (2006) categorized remix in new literacies into four major types and provided explicit examples. The four types are (1) words and content, (2) words and graphics, (3) images, and (4) animation, voice, and music. Particularly, under the category of image remixing, this type of remix is often used for "fun", "expressing solidarity or affinity" and "making political points" (p. 128). Lankshear and Knobel (2006) explained how various types of remix operating in new literacies and illustrated how certain purposes (e.g. political appeals) can be achieved by appropriately using remix. Furthermore, Jenkin (2006) discussed the issue of political participation of grassroots media. By using the software Photoshop as a tool, individual political participants or campaign groups can produce new photos or videos which make "serious fun" (p. 207). That is, participants may criticize certain political issues by using funny or ironic images. Jenkin (2006) pointed out that software and the Internet enable both campaign groups and individuals to edit and distribute political appeals easily, which changes the role of traditional media (e.g. television) and influences how people can be involved in political activities. More specifically, in terms of multimodal representation of parody, Tryon (2008) discussed online parody videos used for political purposes based on Bakhtin's notion of intertextuality and carnival theory.

In Taiwan, some research into kuso in some disciplines has also been conducted. In journalism and mass communication, applying Bakhtin's carnival theory, Shi (2005) regarded kuso as a way to "play dumb on symbolic order" while Huang (2007) examined the written form of kuso in terms of online political participation. In addition, from a perspective of mass communication, Lo & Lin (2005) discussed the subjectivity of readers in Internet kuso by claiming that different from the traditional viewers, Internet kuso participants can be regarded as active views who can play as both readers and producers in the process of negotiating meaning potentials in the Internet kuso. On the other hand, in marketing, Lo (2006) used the written form of kuso and the contents of interviews as her data to explore the relation between kuso and marketing in terms of the producers' motivation and the Internet kuso's significance to marketing.

1.3 Research questions

Although Internet kuso has been discussed in different disciplines and from various perspectives, kuso videos as an emergent multimodal genre, especially those produced by online individual participants rather than campaign groups, seem to have been neglected in discourse studies. Furthermore, no attempt has been made to develop an analytical framework for this genre. Previous studies seem to either focus on monomodal representation of kuso (e.g. written, graphic kuso) or highlight functions of

kuso and parody without probing its intrinsic meaning-making mechanism. Thus, the present research takes the previous studies as a point of departure and will analyze a multimodal and multimedial kuso video on Youtube with the aim to decipher the complex meaning-making processes and to propose an analytical modal for multimodal analysis. Beyond conventional genre analysis, the present research investigates the performance, power, and meaning potentials of multimodal kuso videos. The research questions are as follows.

(1) From a multimodal social-semiotic perspective, how are the meaning potentials of kuso videos being performed in the process of meaning-making?

(2) In multimodal kuso videos, what accounts as a **mode** and what are the affordances of a specific mode? Or, is it necessary to define mode as a separate unit which creates meaning potentials in the whole multimodal production?

(3) In social-semiotic production of kuso videos, who is in **control** in the process of meaning-making? In other words, in the meaning-making process, how is the **identity** of kuso video being contextualized and being negotiated with other participants (e.g. commentators)?

(4) How are decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization **interconnected** to each other in the production and the distribution of kuso videos?

In fact, the four research questions are closely related to each other. Question (2), (3), and (4) are issues extended from question (1). By a qualitative analysis of the target kuso video, how this multimodal genre (i.e. kuso videos) performs its meaning-potential will be demonstrated by a proposed new framework. Since this research focuses on exploring multimodal Internet kuso, besides genre-related issues, issues related to multimodal literacy will be the other major focus in the research. In question (2), in explaining how meaning potentials can be articulated by the kuso video, the present research will discuss how “mode” as defined by Kress and Van Leeuwen (2001, p. 21) can be further enriched and how its affordances relate to the whole production. Furthermore, another crucial issue in multimodal literacy is “control” (p. 132) negotiated in the process of the production. Namely, the producer’s identity contextualized in the kuso video may be negotiated by different modal configuration and be negotiated with the commentators’ identities. In this sense, corresponding to question (3), how control is shifted in the production will be discussed. Finally, apart from examining various layers of remix separately, question (4) tries to explore the interconnection and interaction between different contextual layers by considering how decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization play roles in the meaning-making process of the production. To sum up, by answering the above questions related to the meaning-making of kuso videos, the present research aims to

shed light on the issues of multimodal literacy and genre-mixing.

1.4 Overview

This chapter has briefly discussed the background and motivation of multimodal kuso research. Chapter Two reviews several key concepts related to the research, such as kuso, genre theories, multimodal communication, production, remix, and projective act of identity, all of which can provide a theoretical basis for the main discussion in this research. Chapter Three not only explains research data, including participants, research site, data collection, and data analysis method, but also provides qualitative analyses of remixing types in the target kuso video. Chapter Four analyzes the target kuso video with a new proposed framework in order to respond to the raised research questions, and it further discusses key issues of multimodal kuso. Chapter Five summarizes the whole thesis and suggests possible implications of this study and room for further research.

Chapter 2. Toward an Analytical Framework

This chapter aims to provide a theoretical basis for the main concepts that will be employed in Chapter Three and Chapter Four. Since the present research aims to explore how the meaning potentials of multimodal kuso videos as a genre are performed, theories of genre, multimodality, and identity closely related to the central issues are synthesized in the chapter. Section 2.1 provides a theoretical account of how genre can be defined and discusses what roles intertextuality and dialogism play in producing the meaning potentials in kuso videos. Section 2.2 reviews identity-related theories to explain how identities are contextualized in kuso videos in the process of decontextualization and recontextualization. Section 2.3 synthesizes crucial theories of multimodal communication, especially those proposed by Kress and Van Leeuwen (2001). In this section, the four strata (i.e. discourse, design, production, and distribution) in multimodal representation are briefly reviewed. Particularly, production is the main focus because the present research regards the meaning-making process of target kuso video as production. In addition to Kress and Van Leeuwen (2001), this section also reviews Halliday's (1978) theory of language as social semiotic, which plays an essential part in understanding how the meaning potentials are performed in the multimodal genre.

2.1 Genre theories

To analyze kuso videos as a “genre”, it is of great importance to review genre theories and to examine what characteristics of genre contribute to the meaning-making of kuso videos. Thus, section 2.1 defines genre as a process of social practice and performance, which involves on-going negotiation and identity contextualization. In addition, section 2.2 reviews “dialogism” (Bakhtin, 1981) and “intertextuality” (Bakhtin, 1986), which are considered to be vital characteristics in the meaning-making process of kuso, in order to provide a theoretical basis for further discussion of how layers of remix are involved in the kuso videos as will be analyzed in Chapter Three.

2.1.1 Genre as a process of social practice and performance

To explore Internet kuso videos as an emergent genre, it is crucial to discuss the concepts of folklore first because genre can be viewed as verbal or nonverbal representation of human discourse which is a part of folklore. According to Bauman (1992, p. 29), the concepts of folklore appeared in the late eighteenth century, the period of romantic nationalism, when people regarded folklores as the unified languages, cultures, ideologies, etc which helped people build their social identities. In fact, folklore has gained its various definitions in different cultures and disciplines. Based on Ben-Amos (2006, p.3), he pointed out that “While anthropologists regarded folklores as

literature, scholars of literature defined it as culture. Folklorists themselves resorted to enumerative, intuitive, and operational definitions." Although scholars in different disciplines retained diverse definitions of folklore, they regarded "traditionality" (Baumen, 1992, p. 30) as the central feature of folklore. Tradition refers not to the "cultural inheritance" but to the constructing process of creating the connection between the past and the present through interpretation (p. 32). In other words, the social beings, humans, can not live upon a totally newly-made society, culture, or ideologies; instead, present meanings are made based on the connection to the past, that is, the prior experiences.

Nevertheless, the emphasis on folklore has shifted to "individuality" and "creativity" (Baumen, 1992, p. 33). In this sense, folklores can also be viewed as a social practice in which social actors may perform their individual goals, values, identities, etc. When it comes to performance-centered and practice-centered folklore, it is important to examine the notion of performance in the communicative process. According to Baumen (2001), a performance-based approach to folklore "conveys a dual sense of artistic action – the doing of folklore – and artistic event – the performance situation, involving performer, art form, audience, and setting." (p. 165). That is, the whole performance involves not only the performer's own values but also the audience's evaluation in the action of doing the performance. The audience's

evaluation may not be controlled by the performer; however, the performer can control and accomplish the performance by using “keying” devices (Goffman, 1974), including special codes, figurative languages, and prosodic patterns of tempo, stress, and pitch (Baumen, 2001, p. 171).

Based on the above synthesized discussion of the relation between folklore and performance, the present research, therefore, considers kuso videos as an emergent genre. Genre, traditionally, refers to a “conventionalized discourse type” by which literary works are classified; however, the notion of genre has been reconsidered by focusing on the process of social practices made by the genre (Bauman, 1992, p. 53). In other words, genre was treated as a kind of item in the past, whereas it is regarded as a process and performance now with the features of being “systemic”, “open-ended”, and “practice-centered” (p. 57). To sum up, Internet kuso videos can be seen as a negotiable social practice in which interrelationship between the production, the performer and the audience occurs and by which the meaning potentials are performed. Regarding how the interrelationship plays a role in the performance of kuso videos, section 2.1.2 provides a theoretical account.

2.1.2 From Bakhtin’s dialogism to Kristeva’s intertextuality

To investigate how the producer of the kuso video, the audience, and the

production (i.e. the kuso video) interact with each other, the present research employs Bakhtin's notion of dialogism and Kristeva's intertextuality to account for the complex meaning-making process in kuso videos.

Saussure may be seen as one of the important pioneers who pointed out a relational concept of language. Saussure (1986) regarded language as a "social institution" and "a system of signs", and raised the need to investigate "the role of signs as part of social life" (p. 15) in what he called semiology. In Saussure's *Course in General Linguistics* (1986), he proposed the terms "signified" and "signifier" in explaining sign-making by emphasizing the non-referential nature of meaning; in other words, a sign is made by a series of concepts associated with the target object or idea. For example, to write a sentence like "The dog is tame" means a selective process from a series of related expressions that can be used to describe a dog, such as fierce, loyal, sensitive, etc as well as different breeds of dogs like Poodle, Maltese, Labrador, etc. In Saussure's terms, signs are arbitrary because their linguistic functions exist in the language system synchronically. Although Saussure's account for sign does provide pioneering viewpoints on the relational concepts of language, it seems that the role of social context is not the focus of Saussure's concern.

Bakhtin, the Russian literary theorist, emphasized the role of social context in meaning-making:

> Not only the meaning of the utterance but also the very fact of its performance is of historical and social significance, as, in general, is the fact of its realization in the here and now, in given circumstances, at a certain historical moment, under the conditions of the given social situation.
>
> (Bakhtin & Medvedev, 1978, p. 120)

In other words, every linguistic choice and performance can not be separated from the pre-existing social and historical contexts. In this sense, meaning-making involves not only the addresser's intentional ideas but also the addressee's evaluation on the received information in the context of the specific culture, society, ideology, etc. Thus, meaning can never be made uni-directionally; instead, meaning-making, in Bakhtin's (1981; 1984a) terms, can be regarded as dialogism. According to Bakhtin (1984a), dialogue refers not to the actual conversations between characters in a novel but to the personalities, ideologies, and values embodied in characters' utterances. Briefly speaking, the significance of dialogism lies in the speakers' intrinsic on-going conflicting logic and values occurring in the interaction with others.

In another Bakhtin's work *Rabelais and His World (*1984b*)*, he also discussed how one utterance may make an evaluation of other people via carnivalesque or double-voicing. Carnivals were held in Renaissance and medieval holidays when the

whole social order was overturned. During the carnival, as Bakhtin (1984b) said, “Civil and social ceremonies and rituals took on a comic aspect as crowns and fools, constant participants in these festivals, mimicked serious rituals such as the tribute rendered to the victors at tournament…” (p. 5). In medieval times, only in carnivals could the public criticize and parody the authority, power, and social classes. Similarly, this kind of expression in carnival can be regarded as evaluation embedded in double-voicing or dialogue.

Much influenced by Bakhtin’s notion of dialogism and carnivalism, Kristeva (1986) proposed the term “intertextuality” (p. 34). She further proposes three-dimensional “textual space” where dialogues occur among the “writing subject”, the “addressee”, and the “exterior texts” (p. 36). In this space, the status of word from texts can be viewed both horizontally and vertically. In the horizontal dimension, when the writing subject communicates with the addressee, the textual play occurs between the two sides; in the vertical dimension, the texts in the writer and addressee’s communication are also interacting with pre-existing texts within its textual space. In addition, Kristeva believed that texts, instead of being regarded as finished products, are in a state of on-going production as she put,

Developed from and in relation to these modern texts the new semiotic models

> then turn to the social text, to those social practices of which 'literature' is only one unvalorized variant, in order to conceive of them as so many ongoing transformations and/or productions.
>
> (Kristeva, 1986, p. 87)

Not only the writer but also the reader joins in the process of continual production by producing and interpreting the texts.

Due to the "ongoing transformations and/or productions" (p. 87), there may be "intertextual gap" (Bauman and Briggs, 1992, p. 227) between different types of discourses as well as between the producer and the audience. In the producing process, some producers may try to minimize the gap to make their meaning easily interpreted while others may maximize the gap to highlight their authority and creativity. For example, the news reporter usually tries their best to minimize the intertextual gap between the audience, the news content, and the reporter him/herself to make the audience clearly understand the news. Nevertheless, Internet kuso videos may be good examples to show how and why their producers tend to maximize the intertextual gap in the process of decontextualization and recontextualization as a way to show their creativity, to make serious fun, or to distance their personal stance from the meaning potentials. Specific accounts and examples regarding intertextual gap will be given in

Chapter Four.

2.2 Decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization

Since the meaning-making of kuso videos involves a process of selecting available resources, remixing materials, and performing identities, the theoretical accounts of decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization are thus synthesized in this section and will be helpful in developing a new analytical multimodal model in Chapter Four.

The performance-centered approaches have shifted the focus of “context” to the so-called “contextualization” which highlights the process of negotiation in performance (Bauman & Briggs, 1990, p. 68-69). They pointed out that simply using the term “context” to study performance might cause problems because of the “inclusiveness” and “false objectivity” (p. 68) of this term. On the one hand, context is inclusive of many differential contexts, for example, institutional context, individual context, and context of meaning. On the other hand, objectively, context may refer to everything surrounding the linguistic utterance. In order to reduce the possible confusion caused by the term “context”, the term “contextualization” was then proposed. According to Bauman and Briggs (1990, p. 69), “contextualization involves an active process of negotiation in which participants reflexively examine the discourse as it is

emerging, embedding assessments of its structure and significance in the speech itself." In other words, the meaning potentials in performance are not fixed but subject to transformation since the meanings are "entextualized" and are interpreted in the process of negotiation (Bauman & Briggs, 1990, p.72).

Similar to Baumen and Briggs's views on contextualization, Coupland (2007) pointed out that there have been more sociolinguistic theories dealing with the "process of contextualization" instead of "styles in contexts" since style may not merely create contexts but also respond to contexts (p. 17). In fact, this kind of argument was much influenced by social psychologists who tended to believe that contexts are the actual realization of subjective processes; thus, speech style is considered as being dynamic rather than being static (Giles & Powesland, 1975). Namely, the process of contextualization also involves speakers' subjectivity and values in the context.

The terms "contextualization", "decontextualization", and "recontextualization" are borrowed from the notions of "centering", "decentering", and "recentering" in psychological studies (Bauman & Briggs, 1990, p. 72). In discussing how meanings are entextualized, it is of importance to examine how they are "decontextualized" and "recontextualized" in the process (p.72). Bauman and Briggs provided an account for the notion of decontextualization of texts:

> At the heart of the process of decentering discourse is the more fundamental process – encontextualization. In simple terms, though it is far from simple, it is the process of rendering discourse extractable, of making a stretch of linguistic production into a unit – a text – that can be lifted out of its interactional setting. A text, then, from its vantage point, is discourse rendered decontextualizable.
>
> (Bauman & Briggs, 1990, p. 73)

In the process of decontextualization, the performer may detach parts of discourses from the original context and then recontextualize the extracted texts into a new social context. The whole process is called encontextualization which takes place in the reflexivity of the performer and the evaluation of the audience.

In addition, it is in the decontextualization and the recontextulization of previous discourses that a series of social and cultural "indexical connotations" (Bauman and Briggs, 1992, p. 226) are created. For instance, a kuso video producer may tactically extract several texts from pre-existing contexts and remix these detached texts into a new context; under this circumstance, the producer consciously connotes his or her stance in the process of selecting indexical resources (e.g. voices, images, colors, etc). As Coupland (2007) said, "context is also amenable to tactical manipulation, and one participant can engineer another's understanding of 'where we stand in this context',

perhaps to shock, to amuse or to confuse" (p. 17). That is, in this meaningful process, the producer uses available sources to invoke a genre or meaning potentials by his/her own choice and by doing so, he/she somehow contextualizes or performs his/her identity and power in the practice.

To further explore how identities can be contextualized in performance, this section also reviews "acts of identity" (La Page & Tabouret-Keller, 1985) and "projective acts of identity" (Coupland, 2007). According to La Page & Tabouret-Keller (1985), they considered "linguistic behaviour as a series of acts of identity in which people reveal both their personal identity and their search for social roles" (p. 14). That is, personal identity as well as social identity may be acted and achieved by deployment of various linguistic choices and resources. In addition, La Page & Tabouret-Keller also regarded utterances as "acts of projection":

> The speaker is projecting his inner universe, implicitly with the invitation to others to share it, at least insofar as they recognize his language as an accurate symbolization of the world, and to share his attitude towards it. By verbalizing as he does, he is seeking to reinforce his models of the world, and hopes for acts of solidarity from those with whom he wishes to identify.
>
> La Page and Tabouret-Keller (1975, p. 181)

In other words, when a speaker makes utterances, his/her identity may be projected in utterances or performance. Besides, the speaker hopes that his/her personal and social identity can be identified by the audience.

However, Coupland (2007, pp. 110-111) criticizes La Page and Tabouret-Keller's (1985) views of acts of identity by proposing two points. First, La Page and Tabouret-Keller seemed to neglect the social and cultural contexts in which identity is built; thus, the context in which identity is acted may become unlimited. Second, Coupland thought that their definition of identity is somehow problematic because identity can not be owned or claimed by personal feeling. To complement and further discuss the notion of identity, Coupland (2007) provided an account of how identity can be contextualized by processes of projective act of identity, which are "targeting", "framing", "voicing", "keying", and "loading" (Coupland, 2007, p. 111-112).

First, "targeting" (Coupland, 2007, p. 112) refers to how a speaker shapes his or her own persona toward others. In other words, personal and social identities are ascribed to others. Second, "framing" (p. 112) comes from Goffman's (1974) analysis of social interaction in which there are three levels of social frames, that is, socio-cultural framing, generic framing, and interpersonal framing. In socio-cultural framing, socio-cultural context is highlighted because a speaker's identity may be influenced by the social values and speech communities. In generic framing, genre types may

particularly affect how a speaker's identity is constructed. In interpersonal framing, a speaker may utilize linguistic sources to make his or her identity more or less powerful in building the interpersonal relationship. Third, "voicing" (Coupland, 2007, p. 114) refers to how a speaker shows the ownership in his or her speaking. For example, a parody may involve vari-directional double voicing from the speaker. Fourth, "keying" (p. 114) relates to the tone, for instance, easy, serious, or teasing. Fifth, "loading" (p. 114) shows the degree in a speaker's presentation of identity from light to weighty. Particularly, in analyzing multimodal genre, voicing, keying, and loading are three crucial elements closely intertwined with each other and sometimes hard to be distinguished. To sum up, by the processes of projective acts of identity, performer's identity thus can be contextualized in the performance. A more detailed analysis of projective acts of identity in the target kuso video will be provided in Chapter Three.

In brief, decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization do play crucial parts in the meaning-making process of kuso videos. As for how they operate in various socio-semiotic multimodal levels, it will be explicitly illustrated later in the analysis.

2.3 Multimodal communication

To fully explore kuso video as an emergent genre and the feature of this genre, it

is necessary to discuss a synthesized account of genre, meaning-making mechanism of kuso, and multimodality. Since section 2.1 and 2.2 have reviewed the notion of genre and the meaning-making process of kuso, section 2.3 highlights the multimodal nature of kuso videos, especially with the aim to discover in what aspects and how multimodality plays a role in meaning-making process. Furthermore, because there are various types of remix intertwined in the multimodal kuso, a review of semiotic communication helps to explain functions of semiotic resources and layers of remix in the whole production.

Section 2.3 mainly reviews Kress and Van Leeuwen's (2001) multimodal communication theory, including the four strata in communication and the relation between production and remix, which helps the present research explore how the meaning-potential is articulated via multimodal representation of kuso in the analysis. In addition, with the aim to shed light on the issue of multimodal genre and genre mixing by providing a new model for analysis, this section also reviews Halliday's (1978) social semiotic communication system and Lim's (2002) Integrative Multisemiotic Model.

2.3.1 Multimodal stratra

Multimodality, according to Kress and Van Leeuwen (2001), refers to "the use of

several semiotic modes in the design of a semiotic product or event, together with the particular way in which these modes are combined" (p. 20); in other words, multimodal representation involves the combination of various semiotic modes in making the meaning potential. In Kress and Van Leeuwen's *Multimodal discourse: The modes and media of contemporary communication* (2001, p. 4), they proposed that there are four layers involved in multimodal meaning-making, which are "discourse", "design", "production", and "distribution" (p. 4-7).

According to Kress and Van Leeuwem (2001), discourse exists not only in language itself but also in every entity which serves its function and purpose as they said, discourse is "socially constructed knowledges of reality" (p. 4). In other words, discourse may no longer be limited to verbal discourse; instead, discourse can refer to every socio-cultural entity in the world. For example, even a tea pot has its discourse which reflects certain socio-cultural background, values, functions, etc. In addition, from a heuristic point-of-view, discourse is shaped by a set of procedures which do not need to be followed by a certain order (Johnstone, 2002). According to Johnstone (2002), discourse shapes and is shaped by the world, language, participant, prior discourse, medium, and purpose. In this sense, discourse may not be seen as having a stable and fixed meaning because the meaning potential of a discourse is a dynamic process influenced by its social contexts.

Design refers to the “conceptualizations of the form of semiotic products and events” (Kress & Van Leeuwem, 2001, p. 21). Namely, design sits in between discourse and production, playing a crucial role in utilizing culturally-recognized semiotic resources and modes to form blueprints of the actual production. Generally speaking, production means “the organization of the expression, to the actual material articulation of the semiotic event or the actual material production of the semiotic artifact” (Kress and Van Leeuwem, 2001, p. 6). Nevertheless, meaning resides only in discourse and design but also in production as Kress and Van Leeuwen (2001) said, “Production plays an independently variable semiotic role in communication and does not ‘merely’ realize what we have called ‘design’” (p. 66). In Kress and Van Leeuwen’s account, even if the designer and the producer are the same person, there will be inevitably a gap between design and production to some extent, not to mention that there may be more than one participant involved in the design and production.

In Kress and Van Leeuwen’s (2001) terms, distribution refers to “the technical ‘re-coding’ of semiotic products and events, for purpose of recording (e.g. tape recording, digital recording) and/or distribution (e.g. radio and television transmission, telephony)” (p. 21). Traditionally, distribution only helps to facilitate the pragmatic functions of preservation and distribution without adding new meaning; however, in digital age, distribution somehow seems to gradually gain a “semiotic potential” in the

whole production (p. 21).

Since production per se involves discursive practice, design of semiotic modes and resources, and actual realization in which producers' personal values may be embedded, it can be seen as a complex remix which will be discussed in the next section.

2.3.2 Production as remix

To explore kuso videos as an emergent genre which can be viewed as an on-going process of social practice and performance, the present research regards the target kuso video, including both the video itself and the audience's response to it, as a whole multimodal production throughout the thesis. Theoretically, the present research tries to combine performance-centered/ practice-centered theories of genre with theories of social-semiotic multimodal communication in discussing the particular meaning-making process in the multimodal kuso genre.

Although production refers to "the organization of the expression, to the actual material articulation of the semiotic event or the actual material production of the semiotic artifact" (Kress & Van Leeuwen (2001, p. 6), it still plays an indispensible semiotic role in communication and does not "merely" realize "design" (p. 66). In the process of realizing the design, producers may consciously or unconsciously add his/her personal values, interpretations, identities which may not be pre-designed or may be

intentionally designed; thus, a production involves not only expression, representation, communication but also affection. In this sense, articulation and interpretation are two inseparable and co-existing aspects in discourses as Kress and Van Leeuwen (2001, p. 41) said, “Both articulation and interpretation are forms of semiotic production.” In other words, the articulation of a discourse has its semiotic meaning which may also be modified by the audience’s interpretation, and this interpretation then becomes a new type of articulation.

Production also involves the “practice of remix” in which new texts are made by remixing previous existing cultural artefacts or texts including words, images, animations, sounds, videos, etc (Lankshear & Knobel, 2006, pp. 106-107). Similarly, Lessing (2005) considered digital remix as a kind of writing, such as remixing texts, images, animations and clips to produce new artefacts for young people. In fact, multimodal production per se is, no doubt, a remix which requires both the producer and the audience’s multimodal literacy (i.e. competence) to participate in the meaning-making process. Here, the multimodal remix refers not only to the remix of various semiotic modes and resources but also to the intertextual play between the producer, the audience, and the exterior texts.

2.3.3 Social-semiotic communication

Most of the studies on social-semiotic communication are based on Halliday's theory. Halliday (1978) viewed language as a social semiotic communication system in which there are the ideational metafunction (representation of ideas), the interpersonal metafunction (creation of mood of address), and the textual metafunction (formation of coherent wholes). These metafunctions interact with each other, thus making meaning potentials. However, Halliday's semiotic theory may not suffice for explaining the complex meaning-making process in multimodal videos because of the following two reasons. First, although Halliday provided an insight into language as social semiotic, he did not mention how social-semiotic theory may be applied to analyzing multimodal genres (e.g. videos). Second, his theory may not explicitly explain how the process of meaning-making in video production takes place via decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization.

Applying Halliday's theory, Lim (2002), proposed an Integrative Multisemiotic Model (IMM) as shown in Figure 2-1 to account for the multimodal discourse. As the Model shows, the semiotic meaning is created by the integration of both images and languages at three levels which are expression, content, and context via different media and materiality. The main purpose of the IMM is to synthesize the various research initiatives in the area of multimodality and to propose an overarching research

framework to analyze intersemiosis in a multimodal text. Although this model explains how meanings are made by layers of remix in a multimodal way, it does not include the sound (e.g. music, background noise, song) as a factor in the framework because the study focuses on the interaction between language and image. In many multimodal genres, such as videos and commercials, sound plays an indispensible semiotic role in meaning articulation; namely, the quality of sound, for example, the background music of a commercial or the voice quality of the characters, may influence how the audiences interpret the meaning potentials.

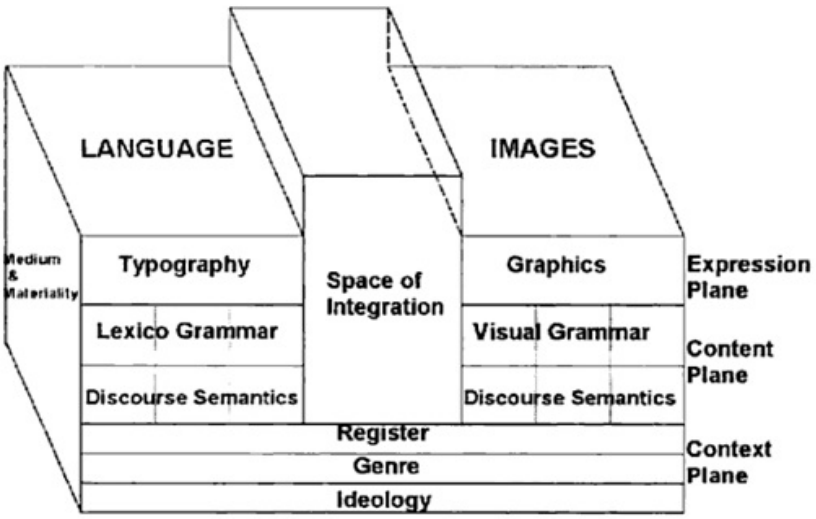


Figure 2-1 The Integrative Multisemiotic Model (IMM) (Lim, 2002)

Furthermore, Kress and Van Leeuwn are also important scholars who have investigated multimodal communication from semiotic perspectives. For example, in *Reading images*, Kress and Van Leeuwn (1996) proposed that framing is a multimodal

principle existing in the composition of visual elements in visual communication. Through framing, disconnected elements can be viewed as separate units in meaning while connected elements can be seen as interrelated to each other in the meaning-making process. Later, Kress and Van Leeuwn (2001) proposed another multimodal communication theory which involves four practices, that is, discourse, design, production, and distribution in making meanings. Particularly, they tried to deal with the issue of modal configuration with various semiotic resources. However, they pointed out that "the shapes of narrative in different modal configurations" and "the question of control" (p. 128) might need further investigation in the multimodal domain. In Kress' (2010) more recent work, he not only further discusses the issues, such as mode, resource, and affordance, but also tries to discuss the issue of "power, authority, and authorship" in response to the issue of "control" (Kress & Van Leeuwen, 2001, p. 21) raised before.

Baldry and Thibault (2006) provided various ways of transcribing different texts, such printed advertisements, web pages, and film texts. Particularly, take for example the film texts which are multimodally similar to kuso videos. They segmented texts into a series of phases and tried to analyzed meanings in each phase constitutive of the whole film. Different from the traditional word-by-word transcription, Baldry and Thibault's phasal transcription for multimodal data did help researchers analyze the

complex multimodal on-going production. Nevertheless, the phasal transcription alone could not suffice the demonstration of the detailed meaning-making process. Thus, by using Baldry and Thibault's transcription system to show the multimodal data, the main concern of the present research is to provide a revised and synthesized framework for multimodal data analysis. Detailed analysis of the target kuso by employing the proposed model will be conducted in Chapter Four.

Overall, in order to propose an analytical framework for the analyses of multimodal kuso as a genre, several important concepts, such as performance, intertextuality and dialogism, in genre theories have been reviewed in this chapter. Moreover, notions of decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization have also been explained since these are indispensible meaning-making processes in the production of kuso video. Most importantly, due to the multimodality of the target kuso video, theories of multimodal communication and social-semiotic communication have been reviewed in order to provide a theoretical basis for the new proposed framework.

Chapter 3. Research Data and Data Analyses

3.1 Research data

The present paper focuses on a case study of a kuso video in order to observe the meaning-making mechanism of multimodal kuso. Qualitative analysis is adopted to closely examine how the producer's intended meanings are articulated in the kuso video through a complex meaning-making process and to discuss how the meanings may be negotiated by the audience's participation in the discussion thread following the target video at Youtube.

3.1.1 Research site

The research site is located at the most popular video-sharing website, Youtube,[1] which was founded in 2005. This site provides a platform for worldwide online participants to share video clips by uploading, viewing, and commenting on videos. To upload videos, online participants need to register as members for free. As shown in Figure 3-1 and 3-2, each online participant can view videos at Youtube by entering key words in the searching box and leave their comments in the blank box following the video. Some participants even make videos in response to the original one to show

[1] The specific website of Youtube is at http://www.youtube.com/.

his/her agreement or disagreement on the issues under discussion. Thus, due to the technological and medial affordances, kuso videos at Youtube as an emergent genre are shaped and constrained by the online environment

Figure 3-1 Searching box at Youtube

Figure 3-2 Discussion thread at Youtube

3.1.2 Participants

Since the present research regards each kuso video itself and any comments on it as one whole production, participants involved in the production are the producer who produced and uploaded the target kuso video at Youtube as well as the audience who left messages responding to the kuso video. In other words, the meaning potentials of the target kuso video are not controlled only by the video producer; instead, the meanings are negotiated in a vari-directional way.

3.1.3 Data types and data collection

Kuso videos are represented by multimodal form which may contain written words, images, music, animation, and video clips. Owing to the complex multimodal configuration of kuso videos, the present research adopts phasal transcription (Baldry & Thibault, 2006) as the main method for multimodal transcription instead of using the traditional word-by-word transcription.

In the process of data collection, several key words, such as kuso, 改編 (gaibian), 搞笑 (gaoxiao), and 惡搞 (egao) are used to search for the target kuso video at Youtube. In fact, there are a great number of kuso videos related to various social issues. The present research chooses the target one which is related to political criticism because of two reasons. First, kuso videos concerning political issues account for a large

proportion at Youtube. Second, generally speaking, political issues may trigger more audience to participate in the discussion thread and to leave messages which show their attitude clearly. As for the sampling process, only kuso videos which are produced by individual online participants are considered; in other words, videos produced by campaign parties and clips from TV parody shows are excluded. However, sometimes the identification of participants could not be clearly shown in online environment because of the nature of anonymity in computer-mediated communication.

The target video is titled “騙 easy-騙選票篇 (攏係假俱樂部)”, which is adapted from a commercial for a shopping platform, several commercials for political campaign, a TV political debate, news report, etc., involving a complex remixing process to connote political viewpoints and stance. In the target kuso video, there are two main characters who are an unmarried couple in the story. The male character promises the female character that he will keep his promise if he is elected as president of a country; however, after he is elected, he breaks his promises and does not care about his girl friend’s feelings. At the end, the female and her friends decide to take actions to express their resentment. As for how this story is used to make political appeals through kuso, it will be illustrated in section 3.2.

3.1.4 Data analysis methods

The present research explores kuso videos from a social-semiotic multimodal perspective; therefore, social-semiotic representation of kuso and multimodality are the most important two aspects intertwined in the data analysis. In order to examine the performance of kuso videos as a genre, the present research mainly applies Bakhtin's (1981; 1984a) dialogism and Kristeva's (1986) intertextuality in genre theory to account for how meaning-making occurs in this particular genre and how the interaction between the video, the audience, and the texts is invoked by the production of the kuso video.

Apart from the genre theory, the present research also applies Kress and Van Leeuwen's (2001) notions, such as "production" and "mode" (p. 21) in multimodal communication theory. In analyzing the meaning-making process in the production, the concept of "remix" (Lankshear and Knobel, 2006), which resembles the notion of imtertextuality, is used to examine what and how various remixing operate in the production for producing meaning potential.

Most importantly, the present research proposes a new analytical model "Functional Multisemiotic Model" (see Figure 4-1) by synthesizing and slightly modifying Lim's (2002) "Integrative Multisemiotic Model (IMM)" and Halliday's (1978) semiotic theory. On the one hand, the proposed model may help to better

demonstrate how meaning potentials are produced at different multimodal levels. On the other hand, applying Coupland's (2007) "projective act of identity", the present research utilizes the proposed model to explain how decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization interconnect with each other in the meaning-making process.

3.2 Multimodal data transcription

Different from traditional word-by-word transcription, the present research applies Baldry and Thibault's (2006) method for multimodal transcription as shown in Appendix 1. In the transcription, a chart is used to simultaneously show the number of frame, time, visual frame, visual image, soundtrack (i.e. music and spoken language) along with a brief interpretation in each time slot. From the left to the right, the first vertical column shows the number of frame while the second vertical column shows specific time of the visual frame. The third vertical column shows the visual frames, which are visual representations corresponding to specific time frames. The fourth vertical column describes visual images (i.e. subtitle and notation of the context) in the visual frames. The fifth vertical column adds soundtrack (i.e. music and spoken language) to the synchronic visual frames. In the soundtrack column, a bracket is used to indicate the switch of style from Mandarin to Taiwanese, while a parenthesis is used to provide the translation of the utterances. The last column gives a brief interpretation

of each frame. The frames are vertically connected to each other in order.

An example of how to read a frame is given in Figure. 3-3. In this time slot, the first three columns from the left show the number of frame (3), the time frame (0:05), and the visual frame in this time slot. The column of visual image shows the written subtitle "*投給我!*" (*Vote for me*) and provides notation of the context in this frame by using a parenthesis "*(A couple is watching Ma's commercial.)*". The notation of context may help readers understand the transition between each frame. As for the soundtrack in this frame, the male character says "*投給我*" to the female character in a rather sincere tone. To sum up, in this time frame, the relationship between the presidential candidate and his voter seems to be framed as the relationship between a young man and his girlfriend.

Number of Frame	**Time**	**Visual frame**	**Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)**	**Soundtrack (music, spoken language)**	**Brief interpretation**
3	0:05		(A couple is watching Ma's commercial.) 投給我!	投給我! (Vote for me!)	Relationship : girlfriend vs. boyfriend→ Ma vs. his voter

Figure 3-3 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 3

3.3 Data analyses: Performance of kuso videos

In consideration of the nature of semiotic production of the kuso video, the present research proposes that there are mainly three layers of remix interacting with each other in the kuso video. Section 3.3.1.1 is concerned with the remix of different “modes”, “materials”, and “senses” which create meaning potentials to the whole production (Kress & Van Leeuwen, 2001, p. 27). Section 3.3.1.2 explains the remix of symbolic meaning in which semiotic principles, “provenance” and “experiential meaning potential”, play crucial roles (p. 74). Section 3.3.1.3 discusses the remix of negotiated identity invoked by the producer’s and the audience’s production of the kuso video.

3.3.1 Layer 1: Remix of modes, materials and senses

Due to the nature of multimodality and multimediality of videos, various semiotic modes (e.g. color and voice), senses (e.g. visual, audio, and tactile senses), and materials (e.g. dialect, style, and item) are involved in the meaning production of videos. According to Kress & Van Leeuwen (2001, p. 21-22), modes can be utilized as a kind of “semiotic resources” which may add meanings in the realization of the design. Furthermore, the semiotic resources are “socially shaped and culturally given” (Kress, 2010, p. 79). That is, certain semiotic resources are meaningful in specific socio-cultural context in which meaning potentials of a mode can be achieved. That is why semiotic

research on mode tends to focus on both the “affordances of the material ‘stuff’ of the mode” and the “work done in social life with that material over often very long periods” (p. 80). To sum up, the affordances of a mode and the duration of a mode in a socio-cultural context are two crucial issues in determining whether a mode can count as a “meaningful” mode. The explicit discussion of modal affordances will be provided in section 4.4.

The representation of a mode can range from small features to large cultural artefacts depending on its semiotic role in the context. For example, color (e.g. red) may be seen as a mode in making meaning potentials (e.g. passion and blessing) in Chinese culture (socio-cultural context). In addition, quality of sound (e.g. loudness and roughness) is an important mode in role-playing (e.g. pirate as a masculine character) in movies. Furthermore, mode can also be represented by objects, such as architecture (e.g. skyscraper and villa) and furniture (e.g. countryside and Mediterranean style) as long as it plays a role in the semiotic meaning realization. However, since mode is society-specific and context-dependent, it is not always static and unchanged.

In discussing mode as a semiotic resource, the materiality of a mode and senses involved in a mode can not be neglected as Kress and Van Leeuwen (2001) said, “In semiosis the materiality of modes interacts with the materiality of specific senses, even though modes are conventionalisations produced through cultural action over time, and

therefore abstract in relation to any one particular action" because human experiences are physical and physiological (p. 28); in other words, mode, sense, and materiality are interrelated to each other, playing a synthetic role in making semiotic meanings.

In the target kuso video, there are kinds of modes at work mediated via various senses and materials as shown in Table 3-1. The horizontal arrow across modes, senses, and materials means that there are different senses and materials constituting a mode while the vertical arrow shows the remix of various modes in this kuso video. The present research regards sound quality, style, tone, image, video clip, and context as the six main modes in the target kuso video. Each mode and its interconnection with senses and materials will be illustrated with examples.

Remix	Modes	Senses	Materials
↕	Sound quality	Audio	Tense/lax, high/low
	Style	Audio	Mandarin, Taiwanese, Mandarin with Taiwanese accent
	Tone	Audio	Polite, rude, reckless
	Image	Visual	Cell phone, banner, sewer
	Video clip	Visual, audio	Campaign commercial, news report, political debate on TV
	Context	Visual, audio	Relationship, political context

Table 3-1 Remix of modes, materials and senses

First, sound quality, involving the audio sense, can be seen as a mode via employing the specific materials of sound which are "tense/lax" and "high/low" in this

video. Here, tense/lax refers to the general expression of voice instead of specific vowel quality; high/low refers to the pitch of voice instead of the place of articulation. As Van Leeuwen (1999) proposed shown in Figure 3-4, voice quality, such as tense/ lax, loud/soft, high/low, and rough/smooth, can be used simultaneously with different degrees. In a specific context, some materials of sound may be particularly highlighted to create intended meanings. For example, when a mother talks to an infant, she may frequently use soft, high pitch, smooth qualities which are remixed at the same time. In baby talk, these qualities are foregrounded compared with their ordinary talk with other adults.

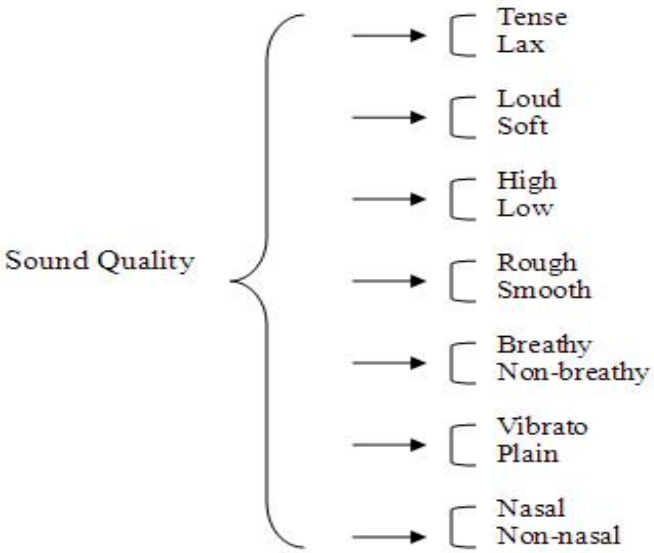


Figure 3-4 Sound quality (Van Leeuwen, 1999)

In the target kuso video, the sound qualities of tense/lax and high/low are especially highlighted as a contrast in the female character's change of attitude after the

male character breaks his promise. For example, in Frame 3~7, the female character tends to use the “lax” and “low” quality of sound when talking to her boyfriend; however, in Frame 13, 15 and 17 as in Figure 3-5, after the female character breaks his promise, the female character changes her voice quality into “tense” and “high”, which shows her resentment and disappointment.

Number of Frame	**Time**	**Visual frame**	**Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)**	**Soundtrack (music, spoken language)**	**Brief interpretation**
13	0:28		(The female character is talking to her boyfriend by cell phone at the airport.) 你跳票了!	你跳票了! (You broke your promise.)	The conversation between the couple→ The promise between Ma and his voters
15	0:30		(Asking her boyfriend to realize his promise) 你要捐薪水	你要捐薪水 (You have to donate your salary)	……

17	0:32~ 0:33		我要去参加 830 了	我要去参加 830 了 (I'm going to join the 830 campaign.)	

Figure 3-5 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 13, 15, and 17

Another example of voice quality as a mode in this video is in Frame 23~24 as shown in Figure 3-6. The soundtrack in these two frames is the narrator's voice designed by the producer. The narrator uses rather "lax" and "low" voice qualities, which may represent a sense of calmness and placidity, to make his own evaluation on the event in the video as the concluding frames. In this sense, compared with the female character's agitation in the story, the narrator's calmness may somehow mitigate the potential political ideology or argument embedded in the video though his political stance is quite obvious.

Number of Frame	Time	Visual frame	Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)	Soundtrack (music, spoken language)	Brief interpretation
23	0:47~ 0:53		(The producer's own voice) 別再期盼 633 - 股票掉到六千三。要實現承諾 - 請馬上捐薪	別再期盼 633 - 股票掉到六千三。要實現承諾 - 請馬上捐薪 (Don't ever expect 633 – the Taiwan Stocks dropped to 6300. To realize your promise – please donate your salary immediately.)	The narrating voice in this video
24	0:54~ 0:58		(KMT's banner as the background) PINEEASY 騙 EASY 騙你選票真容易	騙 easy，騙你選票真容易 (It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.)	The narrating voice implies that KMT and Ma are liars with the only aim to win the vote.

Figure 3-6 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 23 and 24

The above two examples demonstrate how voice quality can be seen a mode in this kuso video. What is worthy of notice is that various voice qualities actually exist in

every utterance, but only some are comparatively foregrounded in contexts for specific purposes and are thus regarded as modes which makes meaning potentials.

Second, style, another mode involving the audio sense in the video, refers to speakers' choice of languages, regional dialects (i.e. geography as boundary), or social dialects (i.e. social class as boundary). For example, in Frame 16, 18, and 19 as shown in Figure 3-7, both the male (standing for President Ma) and female characters (standing for voters) use Mandarin in the very beginning; however, the male character shifts his style (i.e. code) to Taiwanese when he breaks his promise by saying "*免談啦！*" (*Never talk about it*.) and "*我無在驚啦！*" (*I'm not afraid of it*.). The shift in style seems to be used to signal the change of Ma's attitude, i.e. keeping his promise and being irresponsible for his voters. In addition, one thing interesting is that the female character speaks Mandarin with a slight Taiwanese accent, which may be indicative of an unsophisticated woman in this video. In brief, different styles can be seen as modes which add meaning potentials or stereotypes to this multimodal production.

Number of Frame	Time	Visual frame	Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)	Soundtrack (music, spoken language)	Brief interpretation
14	0:29		(Responding to his girlfriend) 那又怎樣?	那又怎樣? (So what?)	……
16	0:31		(Refusing to keep his promise) 免談啦	[Taiwanese] 免談啦 (Never talk about it.)	……
18	0:34~ 0:35		(The male character is hanging out with other girls and does not care his girlfriend's words.) 才 5 萬人的遊行	才 5 萬人的遊行 (It's just a 50-thousand-person campaign)	Indicating Ma's attitude toward breaking the promise
19	0:36~ 0:38		(From her boyfriend) 我無在驚啦!	[Taiwanese] 我無在驚啦! (I'm not afraid of it.)	……

Figure 3-7 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 14, 16, 18, and 19

Third, tone can also play a role as a mode in this video. There is an evident shift in the male character's tone from politeness (e.g. "*投給我!馬上給你633!*" (*Vote for me. I'll realize 633 right away.*)) to rudeness and recklessness (e.g. "*那又怎樣呢*" (*So what?*), "*免談啦*" (*Never talk about it.*) and "*才5萬人的遊行，我無在驚啦!*" (*It's just a 50-thousand-person campaign. I'm not afraid of it.*)) as shown in Frame 14, 16, 18, and 19. The key to regarding tone as a mode in this video is whether tone plays a role in determining meaning potentials. In fact, audio modes, such as voice quality and tone, often interact with each other and are hard to be separated because an utterance may include the representation of voice quality, tone, and style. For instance, in the utterance "*那又怎樣呢?*" (*So what?*), the voice quality (i.e. high and tense) and the tone (i.e. rude and reckless) as modes are remixed simultaneously. As for the grammar of audio modes, that is, what an audio mode may do or may not do, and how it may be used for particular purposes, further discussion on modal affordances will be provided later in this chapter. To sum up, the shift of tone shows that tone serves as a semiotic mode contributing to the meaning-making of the whole production.

Fourth, image, which refers to a specific visual frame here, also functions as a mode mediated via visual sense in this video. For example, as shown in Figure 3-8, in Frame 20, the image of deleting Ma's phone number in the female character's cell phone with the verbal image of "*刪除騙子*" (*Delete the liar*) indicates that Ma is a liar.

Frame 24 and 25 are also meaningful semiotic resources in creating images as a semiotic mode in this video. Particularly, in Frame 24, the verbal image of "*PINEEASY 騙EASY/騙你選票真容易*" (*It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.*) adds meanings to the KMT's banner in the background, indicating that KMT is a liar. As for the verbal image, "*PINE*" in "*PINEEASY*", its pronunciation is similar to "*騙*" (*cheat*) in Mandarin. The video producer may misspell the word "*騙*" (pian) due to his/her unfamiliarity with the pinyin system. Or, it is also possible that the producer intentionally uses an imprecise pronunciation to distance him/herself from the direct strong political stance. Overall, the graphic image and the verbal image are juxtaposed in a visual frame, and thus an image can be seen as a mode in meaning making. Without the verbal image added to the graphic image in the three visual frames, the meaning potentials and ideologies may not be clearly conveyed. As for "how" meaning potentials of images are articulated by semiotic principles, section 4.2.2 will illustrate this point explicitly.

Number of Frame	Time	Visual frame	Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)	Soundtrack (music, spoken language)	Brief interpretation
20	0:39~ 0:40		(Deleting the name and phone number) 刪除騙子? (Delete the liar)		Indicating that Ma is a liar
24	0:54~ 0:58		(KMT's banner as the background) PINEEASY 騙 EASY 騙你選票真容易	騙 easy，騙你選票真容易 (It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.)	The narrating voice implies that KMT and Ma are liars with the only aim to win the vote.
25	0:59~ 1:00		(Ma is in the sewer.) 快躲起來!我不想捐薪水 (Hide as soon as possible. I don't want to donate my salary.)		Ma's campaign commercial for promoting his contribution to Taipei city→ Ma is hidden in the sewer because he breaks his promise.

Figure 3-8 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 20, 24, and 25

Fifth, a visual and audio representation of video clips can be a mode as well in the target kuso video. The materials of this mode come from extractions of a campaign commercial made by Ma's group, a news report, and a political debate on TV. As in Figure 3-9, in Frame 1 and 2, an extraction of Ma's campaign commercial on his economic policy is presented in the very beginning of the video as a piece of evidence of Ma's promise to his supporters. Besides, in Frame 8, a news report is clipped from a piece of complete news as evidence to show Ma's response to his voters; however, later in the following frames, the male character breaks his promise. Another material of video clip as a mode is shown in Frame 12 which is a TV debate between presidential candidates in 2008. This clip can be seen as evidence to reinforce Ma's promise, "*如果說我們做不到的話，要把薪水捐出來。你放心，捐款沒有問題*…" Nevertheless, in the frames that follow this video clip, the male character refuse to commit himself to his promise of donation.

Number of Frame	Time	Visual frame	Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)	Soundtrack (music, spoken language)	Brief interpretation
1	0:00~ 0:02		(President Ma's campaign commercial on his economic policy- 633)	[Taiwanese] 633 不只是一個數字 (633 represents not only figures,)	Using the campaign commercial as an evidence of Ma's promise
2	0:03~ 0:04		……..	[Taiwanese] 更是咱對台灣的… (but also our… for Taiwan.)	……..
8	0:14~ 0:16		(TV news clip)	人民的聲音，我們聽見了… (We've heard people's voice.)	Using news report clip as evidence to show Ma's response to his voters
12	0:24~ 0:27		(TV debate between presidential candidates, Ma and Xie, in 2008)	如果說我們做不到的話，要把薪水捐出來。你放心，捐款沒有問題… (If we can't make it, I'll donate my salary. Don't worry. It's OK to donate.)	Using debate on TV as an evidence to reinforce Ma's promise

Figure 3-9 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 1, 2, 8, and 12

As a whole, the producer uses videos clipped from the complete ones to create the seemingly convincing audio-visual evidence known to the public. What needs to be highlighted is that the above three clips (i.e. Ma's campaign commercial, TV news clip, and TV debate) per se will not count as a mode if they are presented separately without the contexts, that is, the preceding and the following frames. This is a good demonstration of how the meaning potentials are negotiated through three-dimensional textual space in which dialogues between the producer, the audience, and the pre-existing texts are created (Kristeva, 1986). On the one hand, the meaning potentials of the three video clips may be created through the inconsistency between Ma's speech in the video clips and the male character's in breaking his promise. On the other hand, the meaning potentials of the three extracted video clips may also be influenced by the audience's pre-existing knowledge of the original complete videos which is not shown in the kuso video. Therefore, the meaning potentials of the production are "negotiated" and undergoing a "dynamic" transformational process.

Sixth, if mode is defined in relation to its realization of semiotic meaning potential in the production, the context of the original commercial of PAYEASY may be seen as a mode. In the original commercial, the context is built on a worsening relationship between a boyfriend and a girlfriend because the male character breaks his promise to his girlfriend. This context as a mode adds semiotic meaning to the adapted kuso video,

implying that the relationship between President Ma and his supporters turns worse and his promise is no longer trustworthy.

Overall, the materiality of modes and senses can create “correspondences” (Kress & Van Leeuwen, 2001, p. 66) or synaesthesia in the audience’s mind when they are watching the video; in other words, mode, sense, and material interact with each other and can not be separated in discussing the meaning potentials they created. Although these modes are merely parts of the representation of the whole production, they play important roles in articulating semiotic meaning potentials in the modal realization of the video.

3.3.2 Layer 2: Remix of symbolic meanings

Beyond the most basic remixing level of modes, senses, and materials, there is a need to look at a higher level of remix which involves the encoded symbolic meaning in the production evoked by two semiotic principles, that is, “provenance” and “experiential meaning potential” (Kress & Van Leeuwen, 2001, p. 74). At this layer of remix, meaning is not directly articulated in the present contexts; instead, meaning is indirectly evoked by signifiers from other contexts and personal experiences.

3.3.2.1 Semiotic principle: Provenance

The notion of provenance is similar to what Barthes (1977) called myth and connotation which refer to how the secondary meaning deriving from myth and connotation plays a connotative role in the background of the original denotative sign, thus making the new sign ideological in nature. Based on Barthes' "myth" and "connotation", Kress and Van Leeuwen (2001, p. 72) further proposed the notion of "provenance", suggesting that meaning is signified through the use of mythical or connotational signifiers, which add complex ideas from other domains to the meaning-making in present contexts. Importantly, the notion of provenance may lead to "imprecision" of the meanings as Kress and Van Leeuwen (2001) said,

> 'Mythical' signifiers signify whole discourses, in the sense in which we have used the term in this book: a version of events (e.g. what Italians or Chinese or Kings do) together with the (positive or negative) values and ideas attached to this. But these discourses are never explicitly formulated. They are only evoked.
>
> (Kress & Van Leeuwen, 2001, p. 73)

Since meaning is "evoked" by provenance, it is non-neutral and affective often with embedded subjective evaluations. If the audience has the incomplete cultural knowledge,

icons and the products from other domains may sometimes be mismatched, leading to the “imprecision” of the meanings in the new context. In this sense, audience may not be able to understand the new production or may interpret the meaning potentials differently from the producer’s intention. Interestingly, “imprecision” may be related to the notion of “intertextual gap” created in kuso videos, which is the central focus of discussion in section 4.3.

Since the target kuso video is the adaptation of a commercial, which promotes an online shopping platform, by re-appropriating various resources and discourses, it has the nature of “intertexuality” (Kristeva, 1986, p. 34); that is, the target video are created based on the pre-existing texts and resources. In Kress and Van Leeuwen’s (2001) terms, the semiotic principle of “provenance” (p. 74) operates in the semiotic meaning-making of the video by adding symbolic meanings created via borrowing the texts in other domains to it, thus making new meaning potentials in this production.

The most evident example of provenance is the re-appropriation of the relationship between the male and female characters in the video. In the original commercial, the young man can be seen as a playboy who keeps breaking his promises to his girlfriend, while in the kuso video the two characters become presidential candidate and his voter. That is, the whole context of the video has been changed from the relationship of a couple to the political domain. Although the whole context in the kuso video is different

from that of the original, the connotation of Ma's being irresponsible and untrustworthy seems to be borrowed from the playboy stereotype in the original commercial.

In addition, as shown in Figure 3-10, Frame 20 exemplifies how provenance works in creating symbolic meanings in the kuso video. In the original commercial, the young woman deletes her boyfriend's cell phone number because her boyfriend has broken his promises several times. However, in the kuso video, the photo of the young man in the cell phone is changed to Ma's photo with his name "*騙子*" (*liar*). In this sense, the mythical meaning "the young man is a liar" in the original commercial is borrowed and is re-appropriated in the political context. In brief, the negative symbolic meaning in Frame 20 is evoked by the mythical meaning in the original commercial.

Number of Frame	**Time**	**Visual frame**	**Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)**	**Soundtrack (music, spoken language)**	**Brief interpretation**
20	0:39~ 0:40		(Deleting the name and phone number) 刪除騙子? (Delete the liar)		Indicating that Ma is a liar

24	0:54~ 0:58		(KMT's banner as the background) PINEEASY 騙 EASY 騙你選票真容易	騙 easy，騙你選票真容易 (It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.)	The narrating voice implies that KMT and Ma are liars with the only aim to win the vote.
25	0:59~ 1:00		(Ma is in the sewer.) 快躲起來!我不想捐薪水 (Hide as soon as possible. I don't want to donate my salary.)		Ma's campaign commercial for promoting his contribution to Taipei city→ Ma is hidden in the sewer because he breaks his promise.

Figure 3-10 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 20, 24, and 25

However, in Frame 24 and 25 shown in Figure 3-10, the principle of provenance alone may not be explicit enough to account for the meaning-making process because the present symbolic meanings are not evoked merely by the borrowed images; instead, the meanings of the images undergo transformation after the captions are added. For example, the background of Frame 24 is borrowed from the KMT's banner, which could be regarded as either a neutral sign or a negative sign depending on the audience's

political ideologies. Nevertheless, when the pattern of the KMT's banner is juxtaposed with both the audio narrative and the visual subtitle "*PINEASY 騙你選票真容易*" (*It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.*), the evaluation of the KMT and MA is quite obviously toward negative indicating that the KMT and Ma are liars with the aim to win the vote. In other words, the mythical meaning of KMT's banner alone might be neutral in nature without carrying any negative evaluation unless the caption is added; thus, the principle of provenance may not fully explain the symbolic meanings in this case. In brief, though the image in Frame 24 remains the same as the original one, the mythical meaning of Frame 24 is no longer fixed and is reversed by the producer's selective use of caption.

Take Frame 25 for another example. In Frame 25, the image of Ma being in the sewer is originally from Ma's campaign commercial which promotes his contribution to the Taipei City when he was the mayor; namely, the image is borrowed from the other domain in which a positive evaluation is embedded. However, the positive mythical meaning is no longer carried in the kuso video when the same image is remixed with the visual subtitle "*快躲起來！我不想捐薪水*" (*Hide as soon as possible. I don't want to donate my salary.*). In this case, the original positive connotation does not pass on to the new context; instead, the meaning is transformed from the original positive mythical meaning to the negative one.

From the above examples, to what extent may the principle of provenance work in the production of symbolic meaning is illustrated. Particularly, it is found that the principle of provenance may sometimes be further used by adding captions to the original frame. Since the multimodal kuso is an on-going production, the producer could selectively remix the original image with the newly-added caption to show his or her own ideology. To sum up, at the layer of remixing symbolic meanings in multimodal videos, it is of importance to view the whole context and the series of visual frames simultaneously in that the symbolic meanings do not only reside in every single visual frame but are articulated and negotiated in the serial process of the production and the combination of continuous frames. The other semiotic principle operates in the production is the experiential meaning potential as explained in the section 3.3.2.2.

3.3.2.2 Semiotic principle: Experiential meaning potential

The notion of "experiential meaning potential" (Kress & Van Leeuwen, 2001, p. 74) is closely related to the concept of metaphor. Humans use their body parts (e.g. eyes and ears) to sense and experience the world; thus, through humans' bodily experience, that is, embodiment, abstract symbolic meanings can be conceptualized into concrete materials (Lakoff and Johnson, 1980). Embodiment is motivated by our bodily experiences and it depends on how our bodies interact with the world (Lakoff, 1987).

That is, how people sense the world by seeing, hearing, or touching may influence how the metaphors are embodied. For instance, softness as a quality evoked by tactile, audio, and visual senses, may be used to describe a woman who is tender and considerate while it can be used to describe an unauthoritative or unconvincing officer, depending on the socio-cultural context.

According to Kress and Van Leeuwen (2001), the notion of experiential meaning potential contains three principles. First, experiential meaning potential often expresses values in specific cultures. In other words, people who share similar experiences in a specific society or culture may be able to easily interpret the meaning potentials. Thus, the target kuso video may be understood by audiences who are familiar with political issues in Taiwanese socio-cultural contexts. The audience have known the presidential candidates, Ma and Xie, shown in the video and have probably had a basic understanding of their political views and policies (e.g. 633 economic policy). If the audience is a foreigner who is not interested in the presidential election and is unfamiliar with the economic issues raised in the video, he or she may not have the experiential meaning potentials in mind. In addition, the audience who had seen the original online shopping commercial before may better understand the kuso video than those who have not seen the original one.

Second, in the production of experiential meaning potential, materials have more

than one quality and it normally can relate to other experiences. Take the audiences who have watched the target kuso video for example. While they are watching this video, they might have connection to their own daily experiences in terms of economic situation, job opportunities, and well-beings, all of which formed a basis for their evaluating the meaning potentials in this production. In this sense, some people who have no job may attribute their unemployment to Ma's incompetence, whereas people who benefit from Ma's economic policy may consider Ma to be a satisfactory president. In brief, each visual frame in this kuso video may evoke various experiential meaning potentials from individual to individual.

Third, experiential meaning potential can create a "synaesthetic correspondence" (p. 77). Namely, compared with mono-modal or mono-medial production, the target multimodal video can evoke more experiential meaning potentials easily in that it requires the participants' visual and audio senses to interpret the production. As shown in Figure 3-11, when the audiences are watching Frame 18 and 19, they may have the synaesthetic correspondence on hearing the young man's reckless tone in his voice by saying "*才 5 萬人的遊行，我無在驚啦*!" (*It's just a 50-thousand-person campaign. I'm not afraid of it.*) and on seeing the image that he is accompanied by another female. Due to both the visual and hearing correspondence created in the audience's mind, possible experiential meaning potentials evoked by the kuso video may be the implication that

“Ma’s government is untrustworthy” or “Ma and KMT are liars”. The above example clearly shows how experiential meaning potentials can be evoked by synaesthetic correspondenece.

Number of Frame	**Time**	**Visual frame**	**Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)**	**Soundtrack (music, spoken language)**	**Brief interpretation**
18	0:34~ 0:35		(The male character is hanging out with other girls and does not care his girlfriend’s words.) 才 5 萬人的遊行	才 5 萬人的遊行 (It’s just a 50-thousand-person campaign)	Indicating Ma’s attitude toward breaking the promise
19	0:36~ 0:38		(From her boyfriend) 我無在驚啦!	[Taiwanese] 我無在驚啦! (I’m not afraid of it.)	……

Figure 3-11 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 18 and 19

Overall, the remix of symbolic meanings, involving the notion of provenance and experiential meaning potential, can be seen as modal ensembles which involve semiotic principles of provenance and experiential meaning potential in the process of production and interpretation. In fact, the layer of remix of modes, senses, and materials are closely

intertwined with the layer of remix of symbolic meanings. When the notion of provenance is addressed, modes and materials can not be neglected in the discussion, not to mention that experiential meaning potential is evoked by the correspondence of senses. The other layer of remix of identity contextualization is more to do with the personal or social identities projected in the target kuso video as it will be analyzed in section 3.3.3.

3.3.3 Layer 3: Remix of identity contextualization

As Kress & Van Leeuwen (2001) said, production always involves both articulation and interpretation. In other words, apart from the articulation of meaning, interpretation is hard to be separated from the notion of production since interpretation always co-occurs with the articulation. Audience may have their own interpretation toward the production, and the production with newly-added meaning has its new articulation to other audience. As Kristeva (1986) said, texts can be regarded as an on-going dynamic production because both the writer and the reader participate in the process of producing and interpreting the texts. Therefore, if the kuso video itself can be seen as an anticipated production by its producer, then the anticipated comments (or evaluation) from the audience may also be a part of the production which is not controlled by the video producer

In terms of the interaction triggered by the kuso video, it can relate to Bakhtin's (1981) notion of dialogism and Kristeva's (1986) notion of textual space in that the production of the video involves the interaction between the producer, the audience, and the exterior texts. Importantly, this kind of interaction takes place at Youtube with which people can upload their videos, watching videos, and even commenting on others' videos; in other words, the interaction is afforded and mediated by new technology and Youtube environment. Since the audience shares similar interests in political issues no matter whether they have corresponding or conflicting political values, they can be regarded as participants who also contribute meaning potentials to this genre or new literacy. In other words, the kuso video at Youtube forms a space where both the producer and the audience share their values and project personal or social identities.

According to the above rationale, the present research thus proposes that there is another layer of remix of identity contextualization in the kuso video. Therefore, to explore the performance of kuso videos, it is crucial to address the question of how the production and reception of the target kuso video contribute to identity contextualization in the meaning-making process. The present research employs the processes of projective act of identity, which are "targeting", "framing", "voicing", "keying", and "loading" (Coupland, 2007), to account for how both the producer and the audience's identities are remixed and negotiated in the video.

Since Chapter 2 has reviewed the concepts of targeting, framing, voicing, keying, and loading, the following part only briefly summarizes the key points along with the main analysis. In analyzing the projective acts of identity, the notion of framing needs to be highlighted first. Framing comes from Goffman's (1974) analysis of social interaction. He proposed that there are three social frames, that is, socio-cultural framing, generic framing, and interpersonal framing. The present research regards "targeting" as a projective act in the socio-cultural framing, "voicing" and "keying" in the generic framing, and "loading" in the interpersonal framing due to the following reasons (Coupland, 2007, p. 114). First, targeting relates to how a speaker projects his or her identity to others that can be a specific individual, a group, or even a society. In other words, his identity may be formed or be influenced by the present socio-cultural context. Second, voicing is concerned with the presentation of ownership in speaking while keying refers to the tone; thus, the two projective acts are more to do with the genre types, especially kuso. Third, since interpersonal framing focuses on the interpersonal communication, the content of discussion thread may be triggered and partly influenced by loading, that is, to what degree the producer shows his or her identity in the video. To sum up, in the three social frames, how the producer and the audience contextualize their identities via processes of projective acts will be illustrated as follows.

In the socio-cultural framing, the producer seems to project his identity as someone who might once believe in Ma's economic policy and his promises; in addition, the producer's identity may also target at personas that hold opposing political views against Ma and KMT. The projective act of targeting is framed in the specific socio-cultural context, that is, Taiwanese political context. No matter whether the target personas hold pan-green, pan-blue, or neutral political views, they somehow have certain knowledge and understanding of Taiwanese political environment, including political parties, issues, and politicians. Most important of all, these target personas are likely to be the audience who are able to interpret the kuso video.

In the generic framing, genre types influence how the identity is constructed. Particularly, it is found that multiple voicing plays a crucial role in kuso videos. According to Bakhtin (1986, p. 89), "Our speech… is filled with others' words, varying degrees of otherness and varying degrees of 'our-own-ness', carry with them their own evaluative tone, which we assimilate, rework, and re-accentuate." In other words, how speakers display different voices may imply their "ownership" of discourses (Coupland, 2007, p. 114). Speaking of multiple voicing, there are "uni-directional" and "vari-directional" double voicing (Rampton, 1995, p. 223). Uni-directional double voicing refers to the speaker using the language belonging to others', that is, second voice without raising opposing views against the original voice. In contrast,

vari-directional double voicing means that there is an inconsistency or clash between the re-appropriated other's voice and the speaker's own voice.

In the target kuso video, both uni-directional and vari-directional double voicing are employed. Particularly, uni-directional double voicing is pervasive in Fame 1~22 because the producer only re-appropriates the male's and female's voices, that is, merely using the others' voices (i.e. the male character's and the female character's) as resources. For example, the producer re-appropriates the male character's voice (e.g. *我當選後你就買的起!* (*After I get elected, you can afford it.*)) without adding opposing or conflicting voice. Furthermore, it is also found that only uni-directional double voicing is used in the frames of video clips, including Ma's campaign commercial, TV debate, and TV news since the producer presents the original voice in the pre-existing texts without making changes in voicing. However, interestingly, it is found that there is an inconsistency between the frames preceding and following Frame 16 as in Figure 3-12. For example, the conflicting voice can be found between "*我當選後你就買的起!*" (*After I get elected, you can afford it.*) in Frame 7 and "*免談啦*" (*Never talk about it.*) in Frame 16. It is the inconsistency across frames designed by the producer that somehow not only shows the producer's own voicing as opposed to the original voicing of the male character, especially in making promises, but also helps the producer evoke the effect desired.

Number of Frame	Time	Visual frame	Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)	Soundtrack (music, spoken language)	Brief interpretation
7	0:13		我當選後你就買的起!	我當選後你就買的起! (After I get elected, you can afford it.)	Indicating that economic will be improved if Ma is elected
16	0:31		(Refusing to keep his promise) 免談啦	[Taiwanese] 免談啦 (Never talk about it.)	……..

Figure 3-12 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 7 and 16

Apart from the uni-directonal double voicing, "vari-directional" double voicing (Rampton, 1995, p. 223), in which a clash between the re-appropriated other's voice and the speaker's own voice exists, is also employed in Frame 25~26 in the target kuso video as sown in Figure 3-13. For example, in Frame 25, the original commercial is used to promote Ma's diligence and his contribution to the society; nevertheless, the producer adds his or her own conflicting voicing by the caption "*快躲起來!我不想捐薪水*" (*Hide as soon as possible. I don't want to donate my salary.*) in this frame, resulting in the clash between the re-appropriated original voicing and the producer's stance.

Take Frame 26 for another example as shown in Figure 3.3.3b. The caption "*攏係假ㄟ俱樂部，歡迎作伙來騙鬼*" (*All-is-fake club, welcome to join our cheating.*) per se can be seen as the representation of vari-directional double voicing since "*俱樂部*" (*club*) and "*歡迎*" (*welcome*) normally mean the meaning of happiness and welcome to Taiwanese readers. However, "*攏係假*" (*all-is-fake*) and "*騙鬼*" (*cheating*) indicate the meaning of dishonesty. Thus, there are conflicting voicing and values embedded in Frame 26 to make an irony of Ma's long-stay campaign.

Number of Frame	**Time**	**Visual frame**	**Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)**	**Soundtrack (music, spoken language)**	**Brief interpretation**
25	0:59~ 1:00		(Ma is in the sewer.) 快躲起來!我不想捐薪水 (Hide as soon as possible. I don't want to donate my salary.)		Ma's campaign commercial for promoting his contribution to Taipei city→ Ma is hidden in the sewer because he breaks his promise.

26	1:01~ 1:06		(Ma's icon with "long stay 攏係假") 攏係假ㄟ俱樂部，歡迎作伙來騙鬼。 (All-is-fake club, welcome to join our cheating.)		Long stay = 攏係假 = Ma's promise

Figure 3-13 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 25 and 26

In addition to targeting and voicing, keying is also used in the processes of identity contextualization in kuso videos. The present research also regards keying as a factor involved in the generic framing because keying relates to the tones or manners the producer uses in producing the video (Coupland, 2007). In the target kuso video, both ironic and serious tones are employed. For example, as shown in Figure 3-13, an ironic and teasing tone is presented by the caption "*快躲起來!我不想捐薪水*" (*Hide as soon as possible. I don't want to donate my salary.*) with the image of Ma being in the sewer, indicating that Ma is unable to keep his promise. Take Frame 26 in this video for example. The producer seems to make an irony of Ma's dishonesty by presenting the caption "*攏係假ㄟ俱樂部，歡迎作伙來騙鬼*" (*All-is-fake club, welcome to join our cheating*) along with Ma's image. What makes the caption even more ironic is that the Taiwanese pronunciation of "*攏係假*" (*all-is-fake*) is similar to "long-stay". This term is borrowed from Ma's "long-stay" campaign, during which Ma lived with people from

various walks of life, such as farming and fishing, in countryside to realize their lives and to win their hearts.

Aside from the ironic and teasing tone, a comparatively serious tone is also seen in Frame 23 and 24 as shown in Figure 3-14. In these two frames, the narrator's voicing is employed. What needs to be highlighted is that the narrator's voicing may be seen as representation of the producer's because the voicing is designed by the producer; however, whether the producer's identity belongs to an individual or a political group remains unknown. The narrator's voicing by saying "*別再期盼 633 - 股票掉到六千三。要實現承諾 - 請馬上捐薪*" (*Don't ever expect 633 – the Taiwan Stocks dropped to 6300. To realize your promise - please donate your salary immediately.*) and "*PINEEASY 騙 EASY，騙你選票真容易*" (*It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.*) directly shows the ownership of the discourse, that is, his or her political views and identity which is toward pan-green. Here, the sound quality of "low" and "tense" as a mode adds a sense of calmness to the producer's own voicing. Furthermore, numerical wordplay is also utilized in Frame 23 by making an analogy between "633" economic policy and Taiwan Stock's dropping to "6300". As a whole, compared with the keying devices (i.e. tones and manners) in the other frames, a more serious tone is adopted in Frame 23 and 24. To sum up, in discussing kuso videos, voicing and keying are the two indispensible factors contributing to the meaning-making of kuso which tends to use a

rather funny or ironic expression to achieve meaning potentials.

Number of Frame	Time	Visual frame	Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)	Soundtrack (music, spoken language)	Brief interpretation
23	0:47~ 0:53		(The producer's own voice) 別再期盼 633 - 股票掉到六千三。要實現承諾 - 請馬上捐薪	別再期盼 633 - 股票掉到六千三。要實現承諾 - 請馬上捐薪 (Don't ever expect 633 – the Taiwan Stocks dropped to 6300. To realize your promise - please donate your salary immediately.)	The narrating voice in this video
24	0:54~ 0:58		(KMT's banner as the background) PINEEASY 騙 EASY 騙你選票真容易	騙 easy，騙你選票真容易 (It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.)	The narrating voice implies that KMT and Ma are liars with the only aim to win the vote.

Figure 3-14 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 23 and 24

The other factor involved in identity contextualization is loading, which is

concerned with the degrees of keying, for example, light or weighty (Coupland, 2007). Namely, loading relates to how the producer loads his or her identity into the kuso video. The present research regards loading as a crucial factor in interpersonal framing since the way the producer addresses the topic and presents him/herself may influence who may be the target audience, how they interpret the meaning potentials of the kuso video, and how they interact with the producer and other audience. From some of the audiences' comments of the kuso video (see Appendix 2), it is found that when the issues addressed in the kuso video is considered to be funny or relaxing, that is, light loading, the audience's comments and interaction tend to be more peaceful (e.g. "*很棒的影片/講什麼山盟海誓是黃乙玲唱的*" and "*哈超有創意的/拍手(啪啪啪啪啪)*") no matter whether the audience's values are similar or conflicting to the producer's. However, when the video is considered to be serious, that is, comparatively weighty loading, the created dialogue between the producer, the audience, and the multimodal texts may trigger a fierce debate (e.g. "*在做市長時就沒什麼作爲了!更別說總統任期會有什麼貢獻???*" and "*違法亂紀國民黨，一黨獨大好囂張；無能爲力馬英九，政策矛盾一籮筐。*").

As for the loading in the target kuso video, on average, the present research thinks that the loading is comparatively toward weighty on average, especially the frames shown in Figure 3-15. Importantly, whether the loading is light or weighty is not

dichotomy-based; instead, the degree of loading can be regarded as a continuum. In this continuum, loading can be considered as “comparatively” light or weighty. What is more, in making a judgment on the degree of loading, the audience’s comments can be taken as references because their comments are triggered by the kuso video. Although the producer expresses his values on this political issue in a kuso way which may somehow distance himself from the direct impact of the political critique, his evaluation on President Ma and KMT is toward negative as can be seen in the identity contextualization through processes of projective acts which has been explicitly analyzed.

Number of Frame	**Time**	**Visual frame**	**Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)**	**Soundtrack (music, spoken language)**	**Brief interpretation**
20	0:39~ 0:40		(Deleting the name and phone number) 刪除騙子? (Delete the liar)		Indicating that Ma is a liar

23	0:47~ 0:53		(The producer's own voice) 別再期盼 633 - 股票掉到六千三。要實現承諾 - 請馬上捐薪	別再期盼 633 - 股票掉到六千三。要實現承諾 - 請馬上捐薪 (Don't ever expect 633 – the Taiwan Stocks dropped to 6300. To realize your promise - please donate your salary immediately.)	The narrating voice in this video
24	0:54~ 0:58		(KMT's banner as the background) PINEEASY 騙 EASY 騙你選票真容易	騙 easy，騙你選票真容易 (It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.)	The narrating voice implies that KMT and Ma are liars with the only aim to win the vote.
26	1:01~ 1:06		(Ma's icon with "long stay 攏係假") 攏係假ㄟ俱樂部，歡迎作伙來騙鬼。(All-is-fake club, welcome to join our cheating.)		Long stay = 攏係假 = Ma's promise

Figure 3-15 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 20, 23, 24, and 26

Since the negative evaluation on Ma and the producer's identity are embedded in this video production by employing "targeting", "framing", "voicing", "keying", and "loading" (Coupland, 2007), the kuso video as a production may provide a space for political debate; in other words, the audience who participates in the kuso video by giving comments are regarded as a co-producer who may interpret or negotiate the meaning potentials of the video in his or her own way.

As for how the audience interacts with the video, the other participants, and the exterior texts (e.g. prior knowledge and information on the political issues) in relation to their performance of identity, the present research categorizes the comments in the discussion thread following the video into four identity groups, which are in-group identity, out-group identity, anti-China identity, and unclear identity, mainly based on their political stance. The group of in-group identity included people who share similar opinions with the producer while the group of out-group identity includes people who hold opposing or conflicting values with the producer. In addition, the group of anti-China identity includes people whose comments are politics-related but not directly closely related to the content of this video, that is, economic issues. The group of unclear identity includes people who comment on the technological aspects or the kuso expression of the video, for example, making compliments on the clipping skills. Although the classification of identity groups may not explain every comment following

the video, most of the comments with embedded identity can be categorized into these four groups and play a part in negotiating the meaning potentials of the kuso video.

As shown in Appendix 2, the comments on the target kuso video are categorized into four groups. In each group of identity, only five examples are extracted from the whole comments and presented in Appendix 2, because the present research does not intend to analyze all the comments in response to the video. Instead, the present research tries to illustrate “how” the audience’s identity can be negotiated with the producer’s and “why” it can be regarded as part of the articulation of the meaning potentials in this kuso video. Examples with a brief discussion are as follows.

1. In-group identity (sharing information and values with the video producer)

(1) etlucy

說什麼山盟海誓，

說什麼全力拼經濟，

當選至今，才短短三個月，

你的誓言，像斷線的風箏，

如今才來怨嘆後悔，

啊...633 的支票，原來攏是假。

請用王瑞霞的哪首「說什麼山盟海誓」來唱一下。）

(2) zzztop105

Ma is going to have a nervous breakdown. He doesn't know how to carry out his duty as Taiwan's president, neither do all people in his government. Kick them all out of there.

In the group of in-group identity, the audience tends to hold similar political views, that is, negative evaluation of Ma and KMT, with the producer and the video. However, the audience's comments are influenced and triggered by the processes of projective acts embedded in the video. For example, in the generic framing, the producer employs kuso as a genre, double voicing as the presentation, and ironic tone as the main keying device; therefore, some of the participants also use an ironic or relaxing tone in response to the video shown in example (1). The participant "etlucy" re-appropriates a Taiwanese song to create a tinge of irony in his/her response.

However, since in the interpersonal framing, the producer tends to adopt a more serious loading to criticize Ma's being dishonest, some of the commentators also uses a rather malicious or serious tone to show their agreement with the producer and the video as shown in example (2). The participant "zzztop105" uses strong negative words, such as "nervous breakdown" and "kick them all out of here", to show his resentment toward Ma's government. In brief, how the producer contextualizes his or her identity

may influence how the audience interacts with the video and other participants.

2. Out-group identity (debating political issues/ values against the video producer)

(3) wen056

沒看清楚 633 政見是什麼,就亂說"跳票"???

1.平均每年經濟成長 6%

2.2012 年前失業率 3%以下

3.2016 年前國民年均所得 30000 美金

搞清楚再說!!!!!

查一查選前的文宣!!!

(4) ericlikemila

全世界景氣都不好 憑甚麼要馬總統下台? 拼經濟是一天兩天的事嗎? sigh...

In the group of out-group identity, the audience has opposing ideas to the producer's and shows their support toward Ma's government as shown in example (3) and (4). In example (3), in response to the kuso video, the participant "wen056" argues over the real content of Ma's economic policy while the participant "ericlikemila" attributes the economic problem to the worldwide economic downturn. Interestingly, the

best evidence of out-group identity may be that those comments supporting Ma are labeled as "rubbish or hidden"[2] comments in the discussion thread since the negative comments accounts for a larger proportion of the whole discussion. To sum up, these two examples show how fierce political debate may be created by the video and how in-group identity and out-group identity are negotiated in the comments.

3. Anti-China identity (showing identity opposing China)

(5) Taiwanvava

chinese~ go away

(6) d12076332

馬區長加油!!

爲祖國統一大業做出貢獻

In the group of anti-China identity, participants seem to make comments which are not directly related to the economic issue in this video; instead, their comments are related to the relationship between Taiwan and China. In fact, this group of identity may overlap with in-group identity to some degree since the two groups both make negative

[2] At Youtube, participants who upload the video have the right to label the comments as "rubbish" which then becomes hidden messages. In this case, the message will not show up in the discussion thread unless the audience clicks the link "rubbish message".

evaluation on Ma. However, the anti-China comments in this group can be seen as good evidence of how audiences' comments may be triggered by the kuso video and influenced by exterior texts, that is, their prior knowledge, belief and experiences.

For example, the content of the video mentions neither the relationship between Taiwan and China nor that between KMT and China; however, some participants particularly build an anti-China identity in response to the kuso video by identifying themselves as "pure" Taiwanese as opposed to Ma's identity in relation to China as shown in example (5) and (6). The participant "Taiwanvava" regards Ma as a Chinese whom is not welcomed in Taiwan, while the participant "d12076332" addresses Ma as "區長" indicating that Ma is a district senior officer who works for China. Although participants' comments in this group are not directly related to the kuso video, they are still engaged in building similar anti-China identity and interpret the meaning potentials in the video in their own way.

4. Unclear identity (complimenting kuso expression)

(7) bei2333

yeah, apart from its politics, the film is funny!

(8) m326m117

創意無限.不分黨派.不對人.歡迎分享...加油阿!!

In the group of unclear identity, participants merely compliment on the production of kuso video with a focus on its nature of being funny and interesting as shown in example (7) and (8). The participant “bei2333” may not be interested in political issues, but he/she thinks that the video is funny while the participant “m326m117” encourages the producer and other participants to produce more creative videos regardless of their political stances or values. Even though the participants in this group have the unclear identity toward the political issues in the video, they somehow share the similar identity in watching kuso videos.

To sum up, in the textual space afforded by the video, the online participants build their social identities embedded in their comments. No matter what the participants’ motivations or values in responding to the political kuso video, by doing so their identities are remixed with the producer’s. Furthermore, the meaning potentials of the video can be seen as being negotiable and dynamic because the participants’ comments with various identities embedded form a “new articulation” of the whole production, including the video itself and the meaning potentials of their comments. This new articulation may also play a role in influencing how the new audience, who watches the video and the following comments for the first time, interprets the meaning potentials of

the kuso video.

Take commentators (1)~(8) for examples. Commentator (1) and (2) share very similar evaluation of Ma with the video producer, thus somehow strengthening the negative evaluation, i.e. Ma is a liar, embedded in the meaning potentials. Commentator (3) and (4) argue for Ma's economic policy and try to explain the cause of economic downturn. In this sense, the negative evaluation in the video and in the comments from the group of in-group identity is being negotiated by commentator (3) and (4) because their comments add positive evaluation to the negative one. Their positive evaluation of Ma can trigger further debate and provide information which is different from the video to new audiences, who watch the kuso video or join the discussion thread for the first time. As for commentator (5) and (6), their anti-China identity adds even more negative evaluation of Ma regarding his national identity to the meaning potentials of the kuso video by criticizing Ma's national identity. Commentator (7) and (8) do not join in the political debate; instead, they merely compliment on the creative kuso production. In other words, commentator (7) and (8) may regard the meaning potentials of the kuso video not as a political issue but as encouragement of kuso production regardless of its ideologies embedded in the content.

Since how the meaning potentials of the kuso video are articulated through the three layers of remix, which are "remix of modes, senses, and materials", "remix of

symbolic meanings", and "remix of identity contextualization", has been explicitly analyzed with examples, the next section proposes a new framework that can be used to analyze multimodal genre in terms its meaning-making process, especially kuso videos.

Chapter 4. Further Analyses and Discussions

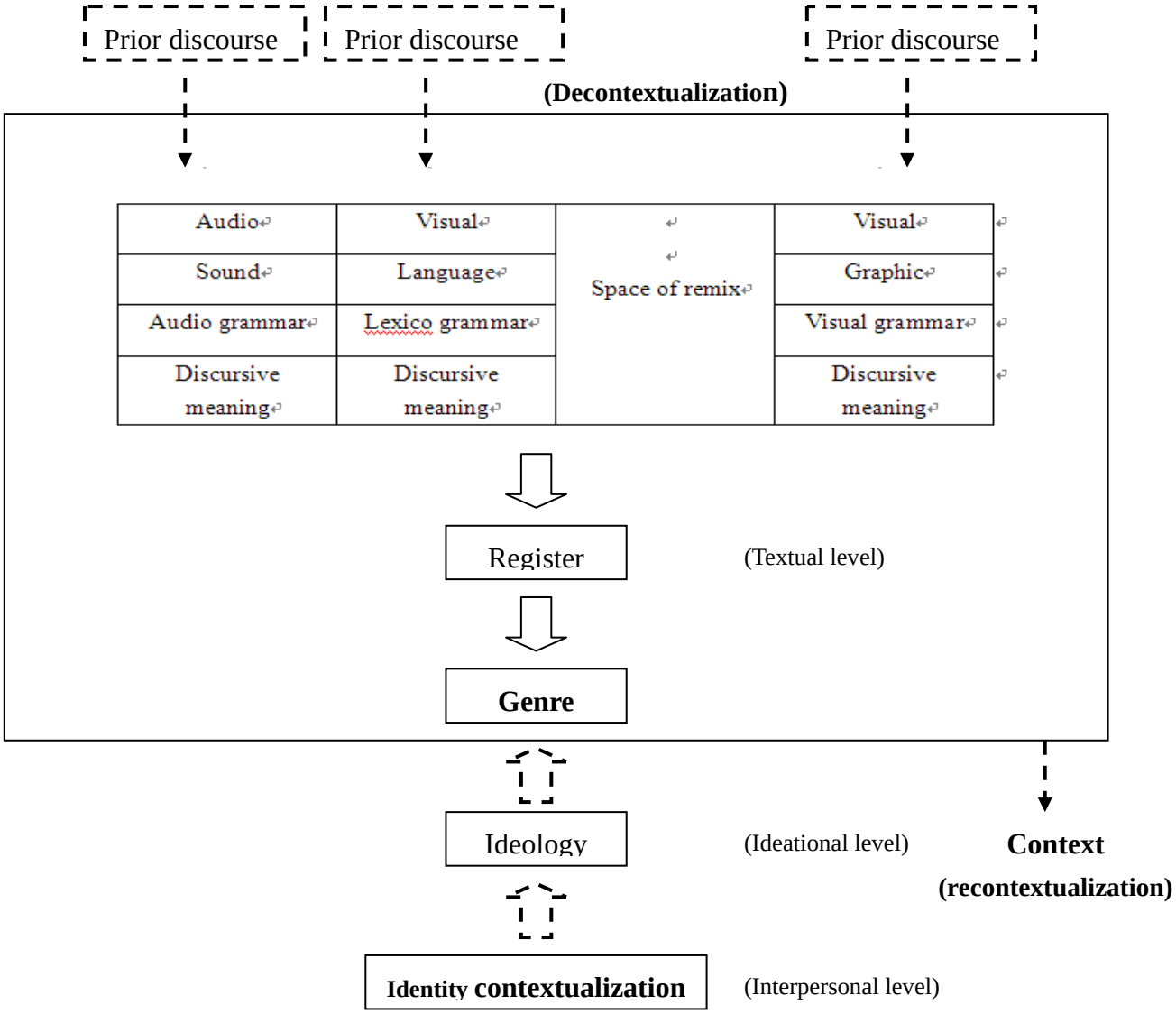
After the analyses of the three layers of remix separately in the previous chapter, section 4.1 proposes a new framework “Functional Multisemiotic Model” to account for the meaning-making mechanism in multimodal kuso. Applying the new framework, section 4.2 further illustrates with examples how decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization operate in the meaning-making process. Section 4.3 discusses the issue of “control” and “intertextual gap” while section 4.4 addresses the issue of “mode” regarding its affordances in the production of kuso videos.

4.1 New framework for multimodal genre analysis

As discussed in section 2.3.3, in the study of social semiotic communication, Halliday (1978) proposed that there are three metafunctions in communication: ideationa, interpersonal, and textual. Specifically, in multimodal communication, Kress and Van Leeuwn (2001) proposed a multimodal communication theory which involves four practices, i.e. discourse, design, production, and distribution, in the meaning-making process. Later, Lim (2002), proposed an Integrative Multisemiotic Model (IMM) (see Figure 2-1) to account for how the semiotic meaning is created via

remix of images and languages at levels of expression, content, and context. Furthermore, Baldry and Thibault (2006) employed phasal transcription to analyze the complex multimodal production (e.g. film and commercial). Although the above studies help explain how meaning potentials can be articulated, the accounts may not be explicit enough to demonstrate a detailed meaning-making process in relation to levels of metafunction.

Therefore, this section proposes a new framework as shown in Figure 4-1 to account for how the kuso video as a multimodal genre achieves its negotiated meaning-potential via decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization. The model is entitled “Functional Multisemiotic Model”. Particularly, this model not only highlights how the process of meaning-making via various kinds of remix contributes to the meaning potentials of kuso videos as a multimodal genre, but also illustrates how the three levels of communicative function operating in the production.



(Including the identities of the video and the audiences' comments)

Figure 4-1 Functional Multisemiotic Model

In using this model to analyze multimodal kuso, first, it is important to examine what semiotic resources are involved in the formation of textual coherence at the textual level. As shown in Figure 4-1, the chart at the upper middle of this model involves senses (i.e. audio and visual), materials (i.e. sound, language, and graphic), and modes (i.e. audio, lexico, and visual grammar). The grammar of modes carries discursive

meanings, forming integrated meanings in the “space of remix”. In other words, the meaning potentials articulated by modal configuration of sounds, languages, and graphics form coherent wholes as a “register” (Halliday, 1978; Leckie-Tarry, 1995; Holmes, 2001) at this level of production. The term “register” is defined as “the configuration of semantic resources that the member of a culture typically associates with a situation type” and “the meaning potential that is accessible in a given social context” (Halliday, 1978, p. 111). In other words, register is often used to describe a specific situation of language use by a certain group.

Furthermore, it is worthy of note that the materials and modes remixed at the textual level are actually borrowed from “prior discourses” as indicated in dotted boxes above the remix chart; namely, a process of decontextualization (Coupland, 2007, p. 155) occurs in the re-appropriation of the semiotic resources. While pieces of texts are detached from their original contexts and are then given a new context (i.e. the biggest box in the model), new meaning potentials (i.e. articulation of kuso) is created in the intertextual gap in the process of recontextualization. In addition, prior discourse may refer to not only the pre-existing concrete semiotic resources but also the audiences’ prior experiences. As analyzed in section 3.3.2.2, the experiential meaning potential is created when audiences relate their prior experiences to the interpretation of the present production. In this sense, the prior discourse can not be seen as being fixed; instead, it is

dynamic and partially audience-oriented. Therefore, each dotted box is used to indicate the flexibility of which a “prior discourse” is to be used.

Regarding the new context in which the meaning potentials are created, it is important to note that it would be easier for both the producer and the audience to comprehend and interpret this production if they have similar background knowledge or values. As Ben-Amos (2006, p. 12) pointed out, “for the folkloric act to happen, two social conditions are necessary: both the performances and the audience have to be in the same situation and be part of the same referee group.” In other words, participants who are able to comprehend this folklore need to “speak same language, share similar values, beliefs, and background knowledge, have the system of codes and signs for social interaction.” (p. 13). To sum up, at the textual level, by remixing various resources in a new context, that is, recontextualization, a particular register of kuso is formed to articulate meaning potentials in the multimodal genre. Since register refers to “contexts of situation in which language is used”, this particular register of kuso is then determined by “situational factors” (e.g. motivation of kuso and function of kuso) and “linguistic features” (e.g. visual and audio grammar of mode) in kuso culture (Halliday, 1978, pp. 31-32). Moreover, because the register of kuso serves the textual metafunction in the kuso video as a genre, the direction of arrow is from register to genre (i.e. from top to bottom) in this model.

At the interpersonal level of communication in which a mood of address is maintained, how the identity of the production (i.e. the kuso video) and the reception (i.e. the audiences) is contextualized shows the interpersonal function of multimodal genre. As discussed in section 3.3.3, the layer of remix of identity contextualization involves the use of targeting, framing, voicing, keying, and loading in the target kuso video as well as the reception of the audience triggered by the video. Since how the identity of the production is contextualized influences how audiences interpret the meaning potentials, the present research regards identity contextualization as a meaning-making process operating at the interpersonal level in the Functional Multisemiotic Model. Importantly, since it is the remix of identity contextualization as shown in the bottom part of this model that contributes to the formation of ideology, including the video producer's and the audiences' identities, the direction of arrow is from identity contextualization to ideology (i.e. from bottom to top) in this model.

Apart from the textual level and interpersonal level of communication embedded in the meaning-making process of multimodal genre, ideology, which involves a set of embedded evaluations contributing to the meaning potentials of the kuso, is formed at the ideational level at which ideas are represented. In other words, ideology serves the ideational metafunction in this multimodal kuso as a genre; therefore, the direction of arrow is from ideology to genre (i.e. from bottom to top).

As a whole, the Functional Multisemiotic Model illustrates how meaning potentials of a multimodal genre are articulated through a process of decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization; in addition, the model also explains how the three metafunctions of communication are interconnected to one another in this genre. Particularly, in analyzing the meaning-making process of multimodal kuso, it is of importance to highlight the processes of projective acts of identity contextualization because kuso, a genre which can be used to play serious fun, is created especially by employment of double voicing and keying (i.e. tone) in the selective process of recontextualization of the semiotic resources. In addition, the intertextual gap between the production, the audiences, and the exterior texts also plays a crucial role in influencing how the kuso production may be interpreted as will be discussed later in section 4.3.

4.2 Interconnection between decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization

This section uses Frame 24 as shown in Figure 4-2 as an example to explicitly demonstrate how the Functional Multisemiotic Model can be applied to multimodal kuso analysis, especially the interconnection between decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization in the performance of kuso.

Number of Frame	Time	Visual frame	Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)	Soundtrack (music, spoken language)	Brief interpretation
24	0:54~ 0:58		(KMT's banner as the background) PINEEASY 騙 EASY 騙你選票真容易	騙 easy，騙你選票真容易 (It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.)	The narrating voice implies that KMT and Ma are liars with the only aim to win the vote.

Figure 4-2 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 24

As can be seen in Figure 4-3, the semiotic resources and related prior discourses in Frame 24 is presented in the proposed model. The performance of this frame alone involves an intricate meaning-making process. First, decontextualization plays a role in the process of selecting prior discourses. In Frame 24, the producer intentionally borrows discourses from (1) the KMT's banner, (2) the logo of PAYEASY, and (3) some prior experiences or ideologies related to the political and economic issues raised in the video as indicated in the dotted boxes.

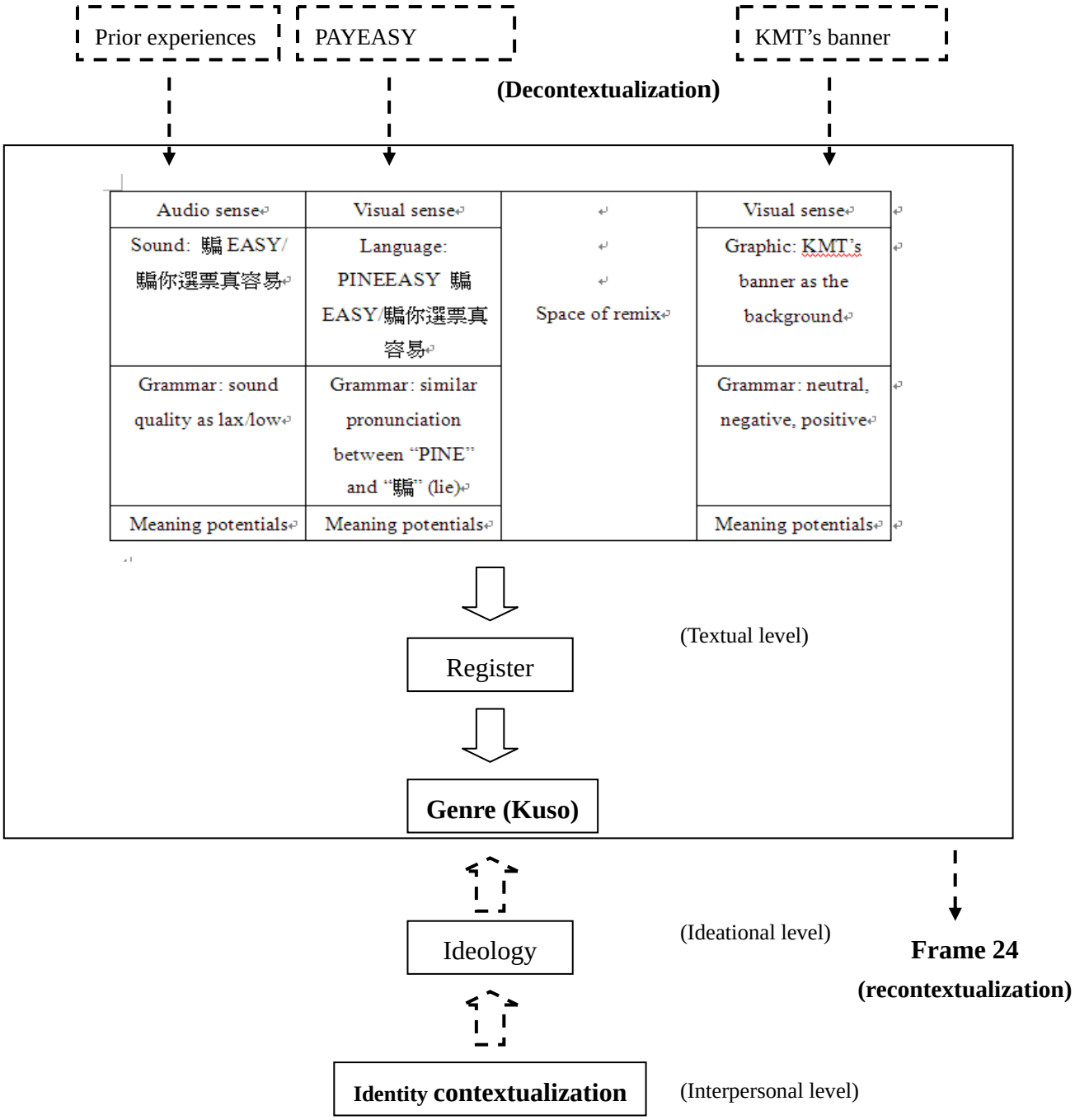
Second, to achieve the designed meaning potentials, these discourses are recontextualized by the producer via re-appropriating the available semiotic resources in a new context, that is, the kuso video. At this layer, the meaning-making process involves a remix of senses, materials, and modes as shown in the chart at the center of

this model. In this case, the sound quality of lax/low as discussed in section 3.3.1 can be regarded as a mode, expressing a sense of calmness and authority. Besides, the visual language and graphic (i.e. "*PINEEASY 騙 easy，騙你選票真容易*" (*It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.*) and the KMT's banner in the background) make an analogy between the pronunciation of "*PINE*" and "*騙*'(*cheat*), indicating that KMT and Ma are cheating on voters. In the process of recontextualization, the semiotic resources are remixed at the textual level and the whole semiotic grammars form a coherent register of kuso in the multimodal kuso.

Third, identity contextualization is also an indispensible process involved in the performance of kuso because semiotic resources are "selected" by the video producer in the process of decontextualization and recontectualization. The "selection" of resources may show how the identity is contextualized in the production in order to create designed meaning potentials. In Frame 24, a uni-directional double voicing, i.e. the narrator's voice, is used by saying "*PINEEASY 騙 easy，騙你選票真容易*" (*It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.*) with a serious tone (i.e. keying). In other words, a more serious tone and weighty loading are employed in Frame 24, which may trigger a more fierce debate among the audiences. That is why identity contextualization serves an interpersonal function and forms an ideology (i.e. Ma and KMT are liars) in this genre (see detailed analysis in section 3.3.3). In the whole production, the on-going

meaning-making process of every single frame contributes to the meaning potentials of this kuso production.

Overall, in the processes of decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization via layers of remix, the multimodal ksuo as genre is thus created which has its own textual, ideational, and interpersonal communicative functions.



(voicing: uni-directional double voicing; keying: serious; loading: weighty)

Figure 4-3 Analysis of Frame 24 based on Functional Multisemiotic Model

4.3 Control and intertextual gap

This section mainly discusses the issue of "control" (Kress and Van Leeuwen, 2001,

p. 128) and “intertextual gap” (Bauman and Briggs, 1992, p. 227) in the production and reception of multimodal kuso.

Nowadays, multimodality and multimediality are characteristic of the contemporary communication. Especially, with the popularity of telecommunication at the Internet platforms, such as blog, Facebook, and Youtube, the power of control may no longer be owned by the party that produces the discourses. In traditional media, such as newspaper and radio, it is the reporter that has the power to shape the meaning potentials of the texts. Although the readers may interpret the texts in their own ways, the interaction occurs merely between the producer and the individual reader who may not have the chance to participate in the negotiation of meaning potentials publicly.

However, in telecommunication, power relationship has moved from vertical hierarchy to horizontal “participatory relations” (Kress, 2010, p. 21). As Kress (2010) points out,

> The redistribution of power in communication, an effect jointly of the social conditions just mentioned and the facilities of digital devices, both leading to the remaking of power-relations, has the most profound effect on conceptions of learning of knowledge and hence on the formation of subjectivity and identity.
>
> (Kress, 2010, p. 21)

In other words, the new participatory culture in telecommunication involves a shift in control of meaning potentials and a remix of participants' identities encoded in the practice of new literacies. As one of the genres in telecommunication, kuso videos at Youtube also share this participatory culture. Particularly, the loading of kuso videos' identity (from light to weighty) may influence how the audiences participate in the kuso production (e.g. actively, passively, peacefully, or fiercely) by leaving their comments. Moreover, the audiences' responses to the kuso video play a role in the negotiated meaning potentials. Thus, the specific issue of how the shift of control is related to the production of kuso deserves further elaboration.

In fact, kuso videos as a genre at Youtube show that control in the new literacy is multifaceted since the meaning potentials are neither fixed nor producer-oriented only; instead, both the producer's design of meanings shown in the video and the audiences' interpretation of meanings shown in the comments contribute to the dynamic meaning potentials of the video. From the producer's aspect, he or she has the control over what semiotic resources will be employed, over whose voicing will be shown, over with what tone the meanings are articulated, etc. From the audiences' aspect, they surely have the power to interpret the meaning potentials in their own ways; most importantly, due to the technological affordances of Youtube, the audiences also participate in the production of meaning potentials and provide their interpretation of the video, as

publicly negotiated in the discussion thread. In this sense, not only the kuso video per se but also the audience's interpretation play a role in the production of kuso.

Furthermore, speaking of kuso production, the control of "intertextual gap" (Bauman and Briggs, 1992, p. 227) can not be neglected. As discussed in section 2.1.2, intertextual gap, a crucial factor contributing to the creation of kuso, exists in the recontextualization of various semiotic resources as well as between the producer and the audience. In the meaning-making process, while some producers tries to minimize the intertextual gap in the production so that the audience would easily understand the meanings, some intentionally maximize the gap in order to emphasize the authority and creativity of the production. Importantly, because of various motivation and functions of genres, the scale of intertextual gap is comparatively different. For example, the intertextual gap in a video for teaching demonstration may be small compared with the gap in a kuso video. Since the gap lies between the content of textbook and the students' knowledge, the video for teaching demonstration tries to minimize the intertextual gap in order to make the meaning precise and easy for interpretation. As for a kuso video, normally the gap is maximized, at least not being minimized intentionally, to create an ironic or funny tone, to make serious fun, to weaken the encoded ideology, or to mitigate the possible controversy.

Nevertheless, whether the intertextual gap is comparatively big or small is

controlled by both the producer and the audiences. As discussed in section 4.2.2, multimodal production usually involves the principles of provenance and experiential meaning potentials. That is, meaning potentials are “evoked” by certain mythical connotations of the production and the audiences’ personal experiences instead of being “explicitly formulated”; thus, in the meaning-making process, “imprecision” of the meanings may occur (Kress & Van Leeuwen, 2001, p. 73). For instance, audiences, who are not familiar with the economic and political issues in Taiwan as raised in the target kuso video, may fail to interpret the designed meaning potentials of Frame 24 (see Figure 4-4), whose meaning is evoked by provenance and experiential meaning potentials. To sum up, intertextual gap is a bi-directional concept to the producer and the audiences. If the producer over-maximizes the gap, the designed meaning potentials may not be well articulated to the audiences. In this sense, it is reasonable to infer that the control of intertextual gap is shifting in the process of meaning negotiation of multimodal kuso.

Number of Frame	Time	Visual frame	Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)	Soundtrack (music, spoken language)	Brief interpretation
24	0:54~ 0:58		(KMT's banner as the background) PINEEASY 騙 EASY 騙你選票真容易	騙 easy，騙你選票真容易 (It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.)	The narrating voice implies that KMT and Ma are liars with the only aim to win the vote.

Figure 4-4 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 24

Overall, the power of control in the kuso production is evenly distributed to the producer and the audiences because the meaning potentials of the kuso video might shape or affect some of the ideology or identity of a viewer, and vice versa. Most importantly, in kuso production, online participants, including the producers and the audiences, are in control of what and how their ideologies are to be articulated as what Bakhtin (1984b) said about carnival. In the past, only people who had the authority, such as politicians and reporters, might publicly participate in the discussion of social issues. In other words, the power structure was built vertically; power was unequally distributed and was hierarchical. However, with the telecommunication tools nowadays, every online participant has the power to make an evaluation of certain social issues and raise the public's attention. Particularly, production and distribution of kuso videos at

Youtube is one of the most predominant ways to criticize or to make an irony of serious social or political issues. Thus, the power structure in the production of multimodal kuso is built horizontally; that is, the participants' power is alternative and equal.

4.4 Mode, affordance, and socio-cultural context

Another crucial issue in multimodal communication is "modal affordances" in relation to socio-cultural context. Section 3.3.1 has provided a brief definition of mode in terms of the concepts of semiotic resources for meaning making, modal representations (e.g. color, voice, and architecture), and its association with sense and material. This section further discusses not only the reach of a mode regarding its affordances and semiotic functions, but also the relationship between modal formation and change of social practices.

Mode, which can be seen as "semiotic resources" (Kress & Van Leeuwen, 2001, p. 21-22), helps articulate meaning potentials in production. As Kress (2010) pointed out, "mode offers meaning-laden means for making the meanings that we wish or need to make material and tangible – 'realizing', 'materializing' meanings"(p. 114). In other words, in multimodal communication, verbal language is no longer the only mode that can be used for meaning making; instead, various modes may play a synthetic role in articulation of meanings. In this sense, meanings are made multimodally. Thus, there is

no clear-cut boundary between various modes in production as Kress and Van Leeuwen (2001) said, it may be better to regard production as “multimodal ensembles” (p. 125) since the modal boundary becomes blurry in the contemporary communication.

In addition, it is of importance to discuss the issue of “reach” of a mode (Kress, 2010, p. 11), that is, the issue of what counts as a mode in a specific socio-cultural context. Since meaning potentials of a mode is socially-dependent and culture-specific, the reach of a mode may rely on a community’s needs or communicative purposes. In other words, a mode established in a society may not be even noticed in another, or the meaning potentials of a mode may be different from culture to culture. For example, the color white used in wedding may convey a sense of purity in Western culture while it may connote the meaning of death and ill omen in traditional Chinese culture. Therefore, the present research thinks that it is improper to define a mode by a set of fixed grammars, that is, rules. Instead, a mode is reached in a specific context in which the meaning potentials of the semiotic mode are activated and highlighted.

As Kress (2010) proposed, the reach of mode involves three interconnected aspects:

> The first is: ‘What is the social and cultural domain that it covers or that it does not cover?’ The second is: ‘What can this mode – image, speech, gesture,

> writing – do in the cultural domain that it "covers" and what can it not do?' The third is: 'What semiotic features are in the mode and which are not, and why?'.
>
> (Kress, 2010, p. 84)

That is, a mode is defined by what it can do and can not do with what semiotic features in a specific context. A good method as suggested by Kress (2010) to examine the "affordance" (p. 84), i.e. possibility and limitation, of a mode is to see whether a particular mode carries the ideational, textual, and interpersonal functions in making meaning potentials. While a semiotic resource can represent the meaning at "ideational, textual, and interpersonal" levels (Halliday, 1978) in production, it can be viewed as a meaningful mode.

Take Frame, 1, 2, 16, and 19 in the target kuso video for example as shown in Figure 4-4. In the whole production, Mandarin is the dominant code used by the characters and the narrator; however, there is a sudden shift in code from Mandarin to Taiwanese in Frame 1, 2, 16, and 19. The use of Taiwanese in these frames does carry semiotic meanings in this context. In frame 1 and 2, Ma uses Taiwanese as the main code in his campaign commercial with a sincere tone, while in Frame 16 and 19 the young man, who represents Ma, uses Taiwanese with a reckless and rude manner in refusing to keep his promise. Thus, the code, i.e. Taiwanese, here can be seen as a semiotic mode which indicates the shift in attitude of Ma and that Ma is untrustworthy.

In the production soundtrack, sound quality and tone are also semiotic modes, which can not be separated from style, in this video. The sound quality of lax/low is shown in Frame 1 and 2, conveying a sense of sincerity and calmness; nevertheless, compared with the sound quality in Frame 1 and 2, Frame 16 and 19 have the sound quality of tense/high creating tension, argument, and emotion. Thus, style coupling with sound quality and tone, as modal ensembles, serve ideational, textual, and interpersonal functions in the kuso video.

Number of Frame	**Time**	**Visual frame**	**Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)**	**Soundtrack (music, spoken language)**	**Brief interpretation**
1	0:00~ 0:02		(President Ma's campaign commercial on his economic policy- 633)	[Taiwanese] 633 不只是一個數字 (633 represents not only figures,)	Using the campaign commercial as an evidence of Ma's promise
2	0:03~ 0:04		…… …..	[Taiwanese] 更是咱對台灣的… (but also our… for Taiwan.)	…… …..

16	0:31		(Refusing to keep his promise) 免談啦	[Taiwanese] 免談啦 (Never talk about it.)	……
19	0:36~ 0:38		(From her boyfriend) 我無在驚啦!	[Taiwanese] 我無在驚啦! (I'm not afraid of it.)	……

Figure 4-5 A transcription and a brief analysis of Frame 1, 2, 16, and 19

To sum up, mode as a semiotic resource is used in ensembles in multimodal production to articulate meaning potentials. However, since the reach of mode is culture-specific and society-dependent, the affordances of a mode may be different with the social changes over time. In other words, semiotic meanings of a mode are not always static but dynamic. A medium becomes a semiotic mode when it meets a community's purpose of realizing its semiotic functions (i.e. ideational, textual, and interpersonal) in a specific social practice.

Chapter 5. Conclusion

5.1 Research implications

The present research regards the emergent genre, kuso videos, as a production in which various layers of remix interact with each other. In the remixing process, including remix of modes, senses, and materials, remix of symbolic meanings, and the remix of negotiated identity, the nature of kuso is realized in production. In addition, since the production is mediated by the video-sharing website, Youtube, online participants are freely engaged in the process of production by responding to the video or others' comments. In this sense, the political kuso video can be seen as a kind of new literacy which requires participants' ability to re-appropriate resources, to make evaluation, and to use technological skills, etc.

Furthermore, in this new literacy, participants with different social backgrounds, genders, and ages have the equal access to participating in political issues and to expressing their voices publicly. In fact, the production of political kuso video as a new literacy resembles the concept of "carnival" (Bakhtin, 1984b) in which various voices from general public can be articulated for teasing or criticizing the powerful authority. Although participants in Taiwan have the freedom of speech in various issues, kuso videos can play a role in encouraging more people to voice their views concerning

political and social issues in a rather relaxing and funny way.

5.2 Conclusion

The present research investigates the performance of kuso videos as a genre, which involves both the producer and the audiences' participation in this social practice. It proposes that the multimodal production of kuso at Youtube involves three layers of remix. At the first layer of remix, various modes, senses, and materials create semiotic meaning potentials in the realization of production. At the second layer of remix, symbolic meanings are evoked by two main semiotic principles, that is, provenance and experiential meaning potential, in the production; thus, the encoded meaning in kuso video can be articulated intertextually. At the third layer of remix, there is a remix of negotiated identity contextualization in the meaning-making process.

In order to explicitly explain how meanings are articulated and negotiated via a complex meaning-making process in multimodal production, the present research proposes the Functional Multisemiotic Model to illustrate with examples how layers of remix operate in the process of decontextualization, recontextualization, and identity contextualization and what semiotic functions they serve at three levels, i.e. ideational, textual, and interpersonal levels. In this sense, this paper may shed light on the intricate meaning-making process in multimodal kuso analysis.

Furthermore, the present research highlights the issue of control in meaning-making process of multimodal kuso because the meaning potentials are articulated by negotiation between the video producer and the audiences. Particularly, intertextual gap, a crucial factor contributing to kuso expression, controlled by both the producer and the audiences, can be maximized or minimized depending on motivations of production (e.g. providing information or making an irony).

Another issue, modal affordances in relation to socio-cultural contexts, is also addressed in the discussion. The present research views mode as a dynamic concept instead of a static one in multimodal communication because the semiotic meanings of a mode may be changed over time or may differ from community to community. Therefore, modal affordances may reflect social dynamics and change in social practices.

Since the present research focuses on a case study of political kuso video adapted from a commercial for online shopping, other kuso videos with various topics may need further examination to see if the proposed model can successfully apply to the analysis. Or, it may be interesting to explore which part of the model may need to be highlighted or even revised to better explain kuso videos dealing with other issues excluding politics.

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Appendix 1: Multimodal transcription of the target kuso video

騙 easy - 騙選票篇 (攏係假俱樂部)

Number of Frame	Time	Visual frame	Visual image (subtitle and notation of the context in the frame)	Soundtrack (music, spoken language)	Brief interpretation
1	0:00~ 0:02		(President Ma's campaign commercial on his economic policy- 633)	[Taiwanese] 633 不只是一個數字 (633 represents not only figures,)	Using the campaign commercial as an evidence of Ma's promise
2	0:03~ 0:04		…… …..	[Taiwanese] 更是咱對台灣的… (but also our… for Taiwan.)	…… …..
3	0:05		(A couple is watching Ma's commercial.) 投給我!	投給我! (Vote for me!)	Relationship : girlfriend vs. boyfriend→ Ma vs. his voter

4	0:06~ 0:07		(選民 vs. 小馬哥) 馬上給你633!	馬上給你633! (I'll realize 633 right away)	……
5	0:08		(選民 vs. 小馬哥) 真的?	真的嗎? (Really?)	……
6	0:09~ 0:12		(A couple is window-shopping.) 喜歡嗎?	喜歡嗎? (Like it?)	
7	0:13		我當選後你就買的起!	我當選後你就買的起! (After I get elected, you can afford it.)	Indicating that economic will be improved if Ma is elected
8	0:14~ 0:16		(TV news clip)	人民的聲音，我們聽見了… (We've heard people's voice.)	Using news report clip as evidence to show Ma's response to his voters

9	0:17~ 0:18		(A couple is celebrating Ma's victory) 當選一百天快樂	當選一百天快樂 (Happy election for 100th days)	
10	0:19~ 0:21		(The male character breaks his promise.) 633 政策我辦不到也!	633 政策我辦不到也! (I can't realize the policy of 633.)	Indicating that Ma breaks his promise to his voters
11	0:22~ 0:23		等 8 年後再說吧!	等 8 年後再說吧! (Let's talk about it 8 years later.)	……
12	0:24~ 0:27		(TV debate between presidential candidates, Ma and Xie, in 2008)	如果說我們做不到的話，要把薪水捐出來。你放心，捐款沒有問題… (If we can't make it, I'll donate my salary. Don't worry. It's OK to donate.)	Using debate on TV as an evidence to reinforce Ma's promise

13	0:28		(The female character is talking to her boyfriend by cell phone at the airport.) 你跳票了!	你跳票了! (You broke your promise.)	The conversation between the couple→ The promise between Ma and his voters
14	0:29		(Responding to his girlfriend) 那又怎樣?	那又怎樣? (So what?)	……
15	0:30		(Asking her boyfriend to realize his promise) 你要捐薪水	你要捐薪水 (You have to donate your salary)	……
16	0:31		(Refusing to keep his promise) 免談啦	[Taiwanese] 免談啦 (Never talk about it.)	……

17	0:32~ 0:33		我要去參加 830 了	我要去參加 830 了 (I'm going to join the 830 campaign.)	
18	0:34~ 0:35		(The male character is hanging out with other girls and does not care his girlfriend's words.) 才 5 萬人的遊行	才 5 萬人的遊行 (It's just a 50-thousand-person campaign)	Indicating Ma's attitude toward breaking the promise
19	0:36~ 0:38		(From her boyfriend) 我無在驚啦!	[Taiwanese] 我無在驚啦! (I'm not afraid of it.)	……
20	0:39~ 0:40		(Deleting the name and phone number) 刪除騙子? (Delete the liar)		Indicating that Ma is a liar

21	0:41		刪除完成 (complete deletion)		……
22	0:42~ 0:46		(Her friends are asking her to come follow them at the airport.) 走啦!我們去嗆馬囉!	走啦!我們去嗆馬囉! (Let's go. We're going to fight against Ma.)	Traveling abroad→ Participating in a protest
23	0:47~ 0:53		(The producer's own voice) 別再期盼 633 - 股票掉到六千三。要實現承諾 - 請馬上捐薪	別再期盼 633 - 股票掉到六千三。要實現承諾 - 請馬上捐薪 (Don't ever expect 633 – the Taiwan Stocks dropped to 6300. To realize your promise - please donate your salary immediately.)	The narrating voice in this video
24	0:54~ 0:58		(KMT's banner as the background) PINEEASY 騙 EASY 騙你選票真容易	騙 easy，騙你選票真容易 (It's easy to cheat voters of their votes.)	The narrating voice implies that KMT and Ma are liars with the only aim to

					win the vote.
25	0:59~ 1:00		(Ma is in the sewer.) 快躲起來!我不想捐薪水 (Hide as soon as possible. I don't want to donate my salary.)		Ma's campaign commercial for promoting his contribution to Taipei city→ Ma is hidden in the sewer because he breaks his promise.
26	1:01~ 1:06		(Ma's icon with "long stay 攏係假") 攏係假ㄟ俱樂部，歡迎作伙來騙鬼。 (All-is-fake club, welcome to join our cheating.)		Long stay = 攏係假 = Ma's promise

Appendix 2: An extraction of audience's comments on the target kuso video

Groups of identity	Nicknames	Comments
In-group identity	HUANGCARRY	馬桶講的爽快,騙的得意台灣人民好騙,才會讓它騙的團團轉,下次 2012 大選照樣騙這是此人本性
	etlucy	說什麼山盟海誓， 說什麼全力拼經濟， 當選至今，才短短三個月， 你的誓言，像斷線的風箏， 如今才來怨嘆後悔， 啊...633 的支票，原來攏是假。 （請用王瑞霞的哪首「說什麼山盟海誓」來唱一下。）
	DS221	失業率 6.03% 終於達成一個 6 了
	rolarenia	是啊，一定要支持他啊。支持他跑步游泳作秀，支持他履行捐薪水的諾言，支持他把雙國籍立委的薪水如數追討，耗巨資重建貓纜..... 六三三大餅總統加油！ 貓纜總統加油！ 綠卡總統加油！
	zzztop105	Ma is going to have a nervous breakdown. He doesn't know how to carry out his duty as Taiwan's president, neither do all people in his government. Kick them all out of there.
Out-group identity	wen056	沒看清楚 633 政見是什麼,就亂說"跳票"??? 1.平均每年經濟成長 6% 2.2012 年前失業率 3%以下 3.2016 年前國民年均所得 30000 美金 搞清楚再說!!!!! 查一查選前的文宣!!!
	Roger101star	支持小馬哥!!!
	rainyboycn	股票，那是因为美国金融危机
	hunthunker	台灣人的錢都被阿扁匯到國外去， 害得台灣經濟一直都好不起來， 都阿扁害的啦。
	ericlikemila	全世界景氣都不好 憑甚麼要馬總統下台? 拼經

		濟是一天兩天的事嗎? sigh...
Anti-China identity	toronto4taiwan	Support Taiwan, Proud of being a Taiwanese
	azdnozzle	bloody chinese MA, go home!!!!
	d12076332	馬區長加油!! 爲祖國統一大業做出貢獻.
	Taiwanvava	chinese~ go away
	WAoMAoZI	八年後咧... 那你這四年要幹嘛? 把台灣送給大陸嗎?? 然後在由中央指派你當區長嗎? 這樣你的 633 就可以完成了~ 連區長這樣貶低自己的話都說的出~ 什麼總統阿~
Unclear identity	ryuinx	蠻經典的 很有創意
	cli00434	GJ!!!!有笑到!!XDDDDDDDDDD
	bei2333	yeah, apart from its politics, the film is funny!
	rhymer123	讚！這個好笑！！再接再厲啊！！
	m326m117	創意無限.不分黨派.不對人.歡迎分享...加油阿!!